Part

Analysing Argument

Essay Structure

Introduction

What you are trying to achieve

The purpose of an introduction is to 'introduce' both the irrefutable facts about the text you will be analysing, and your interpretation of the text. The best way to do this is to connect the text's plain details with your early analysis of what the contention, tone and intended audience.

Include

- Context and contention
- Details (writer, publication, date and text type)
- Major persuasive devices
- Tone (consistant or shifting)
- Intended audience and how you know this

Revise

A common mistake students make is that they turn their introductions into lists of everything they need to include. Remember to express yourself clearly, professionally and with style. This is the introduction to your analysiss and sets your assesor's expectations for the rest of the piece.

Sentence structure

The first part of your introduction should focus on what issue is being discussed and why it is important. This will help you to create an opening to demonstrate a strong understanding of the article, for example:

> *The current trend of dangerous Tik-Tok challenges has once again sparked debate over whether we should be restricting access to the wildly popular app.*

If we break it down it becomes:

- The current trend - **Phrase of recency**
- of dangerous Tik-tok challenges - **Incident**
- has once again sparked - **Verb phrase**
- debate - **Issue**

Here are some sample sentence builders:

Framing Contemporary Issues in Writing: Phrases of Recency, Cause, and Contention

Phrases of Recency	Verb Phrases	Issues
The latest...	...has once again raised...	issue
The present...	...has sparked...	debate
The recent...	...has led to...	argument
The earlier...	...has motivated...	discussions
The current...	...has caused...	disputes
Once again...	...has generated...	altercation
Recently...	...has engendered...	discourse
Lately...	...has provoked...	consultation
Over the past year...	...has propagated...	dialogue

Key Information Phrase

In this section we should include key information that is usually found in the background information section of the text, including:

- Author's name
- Connection of author to text
- The form of the piece, the date and where it was published
- How this links back to the issue you identified in your first sentence

For example, this sentence can look like:

> *Dr Marko Shellius, CEO of Psychiatric Safe Australia, has written a submission to the parliamentary inquiry into social media, in particular addressing Tik-Tok's burgeoning influence over Australian teens.*

If we break it down, it looks like this:

Authorial Context and Publication Framing for Argument Analysis

Author	Connection of Author to the Issue	Form and Publisher	Link Back to the Issue
Dr Marko Shellius	CEO of Psychiatric Safe Australia	Has written a submission to the parliamentary inquiry on social media	In particular addressing TikTok's burgeoning influence over Australian teens

This order can also be moved around as well:

Form, Author, and Contextual Framing of the Issue

Form and Publisher	Author	Connection of Author to the Issue	Link Back to the Issue
In a written submission to the parliamentary inquiry into social media,	Dr Marko Shellius	CEO of Psychiatric Safe Australia	Addresses TikTok's burgeoning influence over Australian teens

Here are some sentence starters to help build these sentences:

Author Connection, Form of Publication, and Issue Framing Phrases

Connection of Author to Issue	Form and Location	Link to Issue
Chief … of…	has written in/on…	in response to…
Leader of…	has spoken at/in…	addressing…
Instigator…	a blog published…	about…
a writer…	an opinion piece published…	concerning…

Connection of Author to Issue	Form and Location	Link to Issue
an opponent of…	a… newsletter	regarding…
a supporter of…	a speech presented to…	encircling…
a member of…	a debate in front of…	surrounding…
a key…	published a…	acknowledging…
an important…	created a…	responding to…
one of the…		confessing…

Tones

Analysing argument involves understanding how authors use language to persuade their audience. This includes identifying the author's tone, which refers to the overall feeling or attitude conveyed in the text. Recognising shifts in tone is crucial as it often accompanies changes in argument strategies. Authors use tone to appeal to the reader's emotions, establish credibility, and guide the reader's interpretation of the argument.

This is the perfect place for you to show the breadth of your vocabulary. Choose a specific word that relates to the article. Always avoid using the terms 'Positive', 'Negative' and 'Neutral'."

Positive Tone Vocabulary Bank

Amazed	Calm	Appreciative	Affectionate	Amiable
Astonished	Casual	Approving	Benevolent	Amused
Attentive	Collected	Assuring	Compassionate	Cheerful
Curious	Composed	Confident	Concerned	Delighted
Eager	Content	Determined	Considerate	Ecstatic
Interested	Peaceful	Encouraging	Consoling	Elated
Keen	Pleasant	Grateful	Empathetic	Energetic
Polite	Relaxed	Hopeful	Emphatic	Enthusiastic
Startled	Relieved	Inspiring	Friendly	Excited

Stunned	Serene	Optimistic	Loving	Exuberant
Surprised		Pleased	Merciful	Happy
		Promising	Romantic	Humourous
		Proud	Soothing	Jovial
		Respectful	Supportive	Joyful
		Reverent	Sympathetic	Jubilant
		Sanguine	Thoughtful	Playful
		Satisfied		Vibrant
		Thankful		Vivacious

Neutral Tone Vocabulary Bank

Admonitory	Factual	Patriotic
Allusive	Formal	Personal
Authoritative	Frank	Picturesque
Balance	Honest	Questioning
Blunt	Informal	Reflective
Candid	Informative	Reminiscent
Colloquial	Knowledgeable	Resigned
Contemplative	Learned	Scholarly
Controlled	Lyrical	Serious
Conversational	Naïve	Sublime
Discursive	Noble	Virile
Distinct	Nostalgic	
Evocative		

Expectant		

Negative Tone Vocabulary (increasing intensity from left to right)

Negative Tones (increasing intensity from left to right →)			
Negative and passive	**Negative thoughts**	**Negative and uncontrolled**	**Negative and forceful**
Negative and passive	**Negative thoughts**	**Negative and uncontrolled**	**Negative and forceful**
Apathetic	Apologetic	Agitated	Accusing
Bored	Critical	Alarmed	Aggravated
Cold	Doubtful	Anxious	Angry
Dejected	Envious	Apprehensive	Annoyed
Depressed	Foreboding	Defenceless	Belligerent
Despaired	Frustrated	Distressed	Calculating
Disappointed	Gloomy	Disturbed	Condemnatory
Discontented	Guilty	Embarrassed	Condescending
Disinterested	Judgmental	Fearful	Contempt
Dispirited	Pessimistic	Helpless	Disgusted
Gloomy	Regretful	Humiliated	Factious
Hopeless	Remorseful	Mortified	Furious
Hurt	Shameful	Nervous	Harsh
Melancholy	Solemn	Powerless	Hateful
Miserable	Somber	Shocked	Insulting
Regretful	Suspicious	Stressed	Irritated
Sad		Tensed	Manipulative

Negative Tones (increasing intensity from left to right →)			
Upset		Troubled	Outraged
		Uneasy	Quarrelsome
		Vulnerable	Sarcastic
		Worried	Sardonic
			Vexed

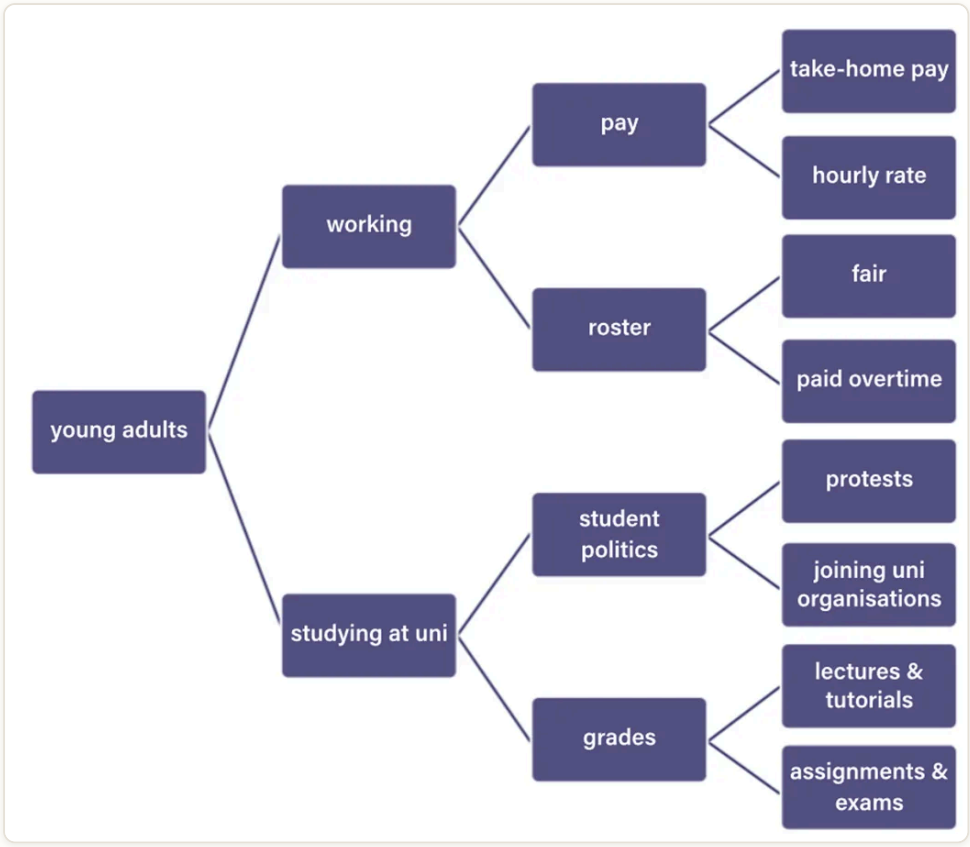
Audience

The audience refers to anyone who is viewing, reading or listening to a text.

When writing an analysing argument essay, it isn't enough to just say your audience is 'everyone' or 'all Australians'. You need to refine your idea of who you are writing for!

Three questions to ask yourself

- What is the author writing about?
- Who would be interested in this topic?
- Is there more than one audience who might be interested in this?



Refining Audience

The key take-away is that you need to be as specific as possible when stating the intended audience.

Body Paragraphs

What you are trying to achieve

Each body paragraph should explore, in sequence, the major arguments that the author uses to support their contention. Remember you are being assessed on your ability to analyse the arguments the author uses and how the language they have chosen supports these.

Step 1: What?

Outline what the author is arguing in your own words. Make a comment on structure; if this is the first or final argument then what is the reason the author introduced this at this time.

Step 2: How?

Begin by identifying the persuasive language features that the author uses to substantiate their argument, include a quote illustrating your point (but no more than 5 words). But this is not enough, then you need to analyse the effectiveness of this approach and discuss how it positions the audience. If there is an image associated with this argument, you should talk about it here - treat it like a persuasive device. Depending on the argument, you may want to talk about how a group of persuasive devices work together.

Note: Try to avoid repetition by constantly stating 'The author uses X which makes the audience feel Y. This can come across tacky and quite robotic. To see examples of how this can be done in a successful way, look at the three high-scoring essays below.

Step 3: Why?

Finally, you need to infer why the author chose this approach, what is their persuasive intent? How would it appeal to their particular audience? How does it impact the tone of the article? How does this support their contention?

Step 4: Examine (Optional)

Does the tone change for this argument? Does the structure change? How does this position the audience?

Conclusion

What you are trying to achieve

In your conclusion, you are exploring both how the text concludes and wrapping up your analysis at the same time. It is an opportunity to discuss the text as a whole, and emphasises your analytical skills.

Include

- Comment on the structure of the article, including whether there is a consistent or changing tone of writing.
- Focus on the last paragraph of the article, evaluating how it supports the writer's contention.
- Evaluate whether the article developed more trust in the readers and explain why.

Note

Some students find they don't have time for a conclusion. This isn't ideal, but it isn't the end of the world, as most of this information should have been explicit throughout. If you are running short on time, a sentence summarising how each argument leads to the contention is sufficient.

Complex Sentence and Paragraph Building

When analysing persuasive texts, it's not enough to simply spot techniques—you need to explain what is happening, why it's there, and how it affects the audience.

Students often start with short, seperate sentences:

'The writer uses emotive language. This makes the audience feel sympathy'

A stronger version combines ideas into one complex sentence:

'Describing the victims as "cruelly abandoned" evokes a deep sense of sympathy in the audience, prompting them to see the government as neglectful and morally failing in its duty of care.'

Techniques for Stronger Sentences

- Subordinating conjunctions – because, although, while, since, if
- Embedded quotes – weave quotes into the sentence naturally
- Relative clauses – who, which, that
- Appositives – a technique aimed at...

By applying these sentence-building tools, your analysis will become more precise, connected, and persuasive—mirroring the sophistication expected in high-level responses.

To help you identify and discuss these elements in a clear, structured way, we will now look at a step-by-step framework that breaks persuasive writing into its key components.

W.A.S.T.E.: F.A.T.!

This acronym is designed to assist you in crafting complex and sophisticated sentences that strengthen your analytical writing. In higher-scoring essays, writers deliberately weave these elements into their work to add depth, clarity, and precision. While it is not necessary to include every element in every individual sentence, you should aim to integrate all of them across the body of your essay. This means that, by the end of each

body paragraph, the reader should be able to identify how you have employed these elements to develop your argument, enhance your expression, and engage the audience effectively. Consistent and purposeful use of these techniques will not only improve sentence complexity but also demonstrate a mature and well-structured writing style.

- **W**ords – Focus on the most persuasive words or phrases of the piece.
- **A**rgument – What is the supporting argument of each section?
- **S**tructure – Where is this located in the piece and why?
- **T**one – How does the author apply tone to be more persuasive in each section?
- **E**ffect upon the audience – How does it position the audience to:
    - **F**eel?
    - **A**ct?
    - **T**hink?

W.A.S.T.E.: F.A.T. Medium Example

The editorial uses emotionally charged words such as "climate catastrophe", "tipping point", and "irreversible damage" to stress the seriousness of the issue. The supporting argument is that urgent government action is necessary to prevent catastrophic environmental collapse. These phrases appear in the introduction so that the reader is immediately confronted with the scale of the problem. The author adopts an alarmist and urgent tone to heighten concern and prompt immediate attention. This positions the audience to feel fear and anxiety about the future, to act by pressuring politicians or signing petitions, and to think that if society does not act now, it will be too late.

W.A.S.T.E.: F.A.T. High Example

The editorial uses emotive phrases such as "climate catastrophe", "tipping point", and "irreversible damage" in its introduction to immediately confront the reader with the scale of the problem. By presenting the argument that urgent government action is needed to prevent environmental collapse, the writer establishes the issue as both pressing and unavoidable. Through an alarmist and urgent tone, the piece positions the audience to feel fear, act by pressuring politicians or signing petitions, and think that immediate intervention is essential.

Fill-in-the-blanks Analysing Argument Template for an Introduction

Your introduction should discuss the writer's contention and intention, the specific audience, the form, and the publication details, as well as the context of the issue. You might like to make a comment about the tone of the piece in the introduction.

Here is a sample introduction structure:

The issue of ..... (issue) was addressed in a ..... (text type) for ..... (publication) on ..... (date). ..... (Author) contends, in a ..... (tonal word) and at times ..... (tonal word) voice that ..... (contention). The piece is predominantly ..... (words about overall structure or style) in style, and seeks to position its ..... (audience) to accept ..... (intention).

Another sample introduction structure could look like this:

Following ..... (context), debate resurfaced regarding ..... (issue). In a ..... (text type) for ..... (publication) on ..... (date), ... (author) argues in a ..... (tonal word) and ..... (tonal word) fashion that ..... (contention), and seeks to ..... (intention). The piece, targeted at ..... (audience), ...

For example:

In the wake of the recent sentencing of murderer John Smith, Sarah Farah's letter to the editor of The Daily Telegraph (9 June 2014), raises the issue of perceived injustice in the treatment of Australian citizens. In an aggressive tone, she contends that the penalty imposed on this man was too harsh and that such punishment represents a form of anti Australian discrimination. Thus, she hopes to prompt the Australian Government to take action to protect its citizens.

Reading the Background and Mapping the Argument

Section C tests three skills applied to a text you have never seen: inferential reading, analytical thinking and clear expression. The text itself is deliberately easy to comprehend. What is hard is reading it *inferentially*.

What You Already Know About Persuasion

Persuasion happens when a reader trusts the writer, sees the issue from a new angle, believes they share the writer's values, and understands what part they will play in the proposal. So in every text you can expect the writer, at some point, to:

- establish their credibility;
- present the status quo as needing change (or as worth protecting);
- reframe how the reader understands the issue;
- present the proposal as consistent with the reader's values;
- show how it serves both the individual and the common good.

You do not know *how* they will do these things. That is what you discover.

Comprehension Is Not Enough

Comprehension questions (Who wrote it? How long has the event run?) are Year 7 tasks. Inferential questions are yours:

- **Who is persuading whom, of what?**
- **What do these readers believe and value?** Infer it from the publication, the community and the history given.
- **What is the writer's relationship to the issue?** An unaligned "local resident" seems impartial and credible. The chair of an organisation that will close has a stake and must work harder against suspicion.
- **What are the stakes?** Asking readers to "consider" change one day is low stakes. Asking them to vote tonight for something they dislike is high stakes, and the writer's

strategy will reflect that.

State these findings briefly in your introduction, so you can draw on them throughout.

Two Recent Contrasts

- **2025:** a resident proposes that a regional town replace a 50-year fireworks tradition with a light show. Tradition is comforting and change is hard, so he spends most of the piece building a case for change, and the stakes are low ("some time in the future").
- **2024:** the chair of a struggling community gym proposes leasing the foyer to a lolly shop. Her readers built the gym for health, so the proposal clashes with their values, and she needs a vote. High stakes, invested speaker.

How Arguments Open

Openings are strategic building blocks. Three common moves (not the only ones):

- outline a situation and frame it as a problem the writer will solve;
- establish the writer's credibility first, so later claims are trusted;
- establish shared values first, so the reader feels on the same side.

A writer who wants a tradition abandoned may open by praising it. That is not a contradiction: shared affection earns the trust needed for what comes after the *but*.

Watch the Hinge Words

But, *however*, *yet*, *until*: what follows a hinge is usually the writer's real point. Mark every hinge as you read. They often reveal the argument's structure, for example a repeated pattern of problem, hinge, then a better alternative.

Explain the Sequence, Do Not Just List It

"Then", "next" and "second" only order the argument. Explain the link instead.

- **Weak:** Next, the writer reframes the status quo as problematic and uses targeted examples to make the audience see the situation differently.
- **Strong:** Having established shared values with his readers, the writer turns those same values against the fireworks, moving systematically through care for the environment, fairness to vulnerable residents, the welfare of pets and economic responsibility. This

relentless return to the readers' own values makes change seem not a loss but the only choice consistent with who they are.

Choose the Most Powerful Techniques

Almost every persuasive text appeals to values, characterises its subjects positively or negatively, and compares the favoured option with the alternative. Beyond those, techniques vary each year. You cannot analyse everything, so choose the elements used most powerfully in *this* text, whether common or unusual. A popular technique such as inclusive pronouns may be the least important thing on the page.

Pace Yourself Through the Text

A common error is spending too long on the opening and running out of time before the argument's turn or conclusion. Plan your selections across the whole text before you write.

Analyse the Example, Not the Technique

"The writer uses statistics to support their view. This gives the argument credibility" would fit any text, so it analyses nothing. Analyse *this* example: "Citing figures from the AMA implies thorough research, and the before-and-after comparison, showing participation doubled, presents the intervention as clearly effective." If your analysis of an example takes only a sentence, check that you are explaining the example rather than defining the technique.

What, How, Why

Every analytical point needs three parts: **what** the writer is doing, **how** (the specific words or image), and **why** these readers, with these values, are likely to respond. Summarising what was said is the "what" alone. It is not wrong, but it is incomplete. As you improve, the three parts can merge in a single fluent sentence; the bulk of a strong paragraph is the how and the why.

The Visual

- **Describe versus explain.** "The image shows a small dog hiding under a sheet" is description. Explaining shows how the dog's small size and cowering posture amplify the written claim that pets are innocent and vulnerable.

- **Analyse it where it belongs.** The visual is part of the text. Analyse it alongside the argument it supports, so you show how it is integrated. Tacking it on at the end shows less skill, but is far better than forgetting it.
- **Tick it off.** Put a tick beside the visual in the task book once you have written about it.

Do Not Evaluate

The specifications state you are not required to evaluate whether the argument succeeds. Judgements such as “this is effective” waste time and earn nothing. Explain how the persuasion works and why the intended readers would respond, not how people in general would respond.

Analysing Written Language

Terms and Strategies

Specific Word Choice (word connotation)

Writers choose particular words to provoke an emotional reaction in the reader or emphasise an idea.

For example, if writing about abortion, the author may choose; "I read with disgust that the government is to ... kill, slay, slaughter, murder, butcher, exterminate, destroy, sacrifice, execute ... Emotive language is language that is not logical or rational - it reflects and expresses an emotional or subjective reaction. Such words help create mood. Many words have connotations or associations that the writer uses with deliberate intent to create a desired effect in the reader. Words may have positive or negative connotations. They may evoke intense imagery. You will be expected to discuss some targeted words and their relative connotations in your language analysis piece.

Particular language structure and features

Inclusive language (we, our) may be used to give the audience a sense of being part of a wider community of thought/action.

Modifiers and qualifiers are words used to denote a level of impact. There is a difference between a writer choosing to use ‘some’ instead of ‘all’ or ‘most’ instead of ‘many’. Phrases such as ‘very good’ or ‘basically good’ also suggest different meaning to the reader. Students analysing language need to consider why specific lexical strings have been chosen by the writer as a form of persuasion.

Euphemisms

Euphemisms are words sometimes used to soften a more accurate but seemingly more offensive word or phrase. For example, euphemisms for ‘die’ include; passed away, lose one’s life, kick the bucket, croak. A company may say they are ‘downsizing’ instead offiring workers from the job.

Hypothetical Scenarios

Hypothetical scenarios are used to prompt the reader to imagine possible outcomes, often beginning with phrases like *“Imagine if…”*. These speculative examples draw attention to

the consequences of actions or inactions, even if they are not real or likely. Writers use this technique to provoke reflection and emotional investment from the reader.

For example: *"Imagine if the world was ruled by tyrants who dominated our every thought daily..."*

Repetition

Repetition involves deliberately repeating words or phrases for emphasis and to make an idea more memorable.

Anaphora: repetition at the start of successive clauses.

e.g. School is distracting. School is boring. School sucks.

Epistrophe: repetition at the end of clauses.

e.g. Follow the rules. Obey the rules. These are the rules.

Puns

Puns are humorous wordplays based on similar sounds or multiple meanings. They are often used to lighten tone or ridicule opposing views. Some puns also carry double meanings, especially in persuasive or satirical writing.

e.g. "Time flies like an arrow; fruit flies like a banana."

Irony

Irony occurs when the intended meaning of a statement contrasts with its literal meaning. Writers often use irony to highlight absurdities or criticise ideas indirectly.

e.g. "Lovely day," said during a storm.

Sarcasm

Sarcasm is a biting, mocking form of expression usually intended to hurt, ridicule, or convey contempt. It often overlaps with irony but has a more cutting tone.

e.g. "Nice face. Shame about the rest."

Exaggeration / Hyperbole

This technique involves overstating a point for dramatic effect. It can be used to emphasise importance or provoke an emotional response.

e.g. "I'd rather cut off my arm than go back to work under those conditions!"

Humour

Humour engages the reader by entertaining them. It can also make controversial ideas more palatable or draw attention to flaws in opposing arguments.

It is often used as a non-threatening way to critique.

Satire

Satire combines humour and criticism to ridicule individuals, institutions, or ideas. It often exposes hypocrisy or absurdity, making serious points in a humorous way.

e.g. A TV show like Frontline that uses mock-journalism to critique the media.

Oxymoron

An oxymoron combines two contradictory terms to highlight contrast or provoke thought. It is often used to emphasise complexity or irony.

e.g. deafening silence, wise fool, bitter sweet

Assonance

Assonance is the repetition of vowel sounds within words or phrases to create rhythm, mood, or emphasis. Often used poetically or in slogans.

e.g. "cool, calm and collected"

Simile

A simile compares one thing with another using the words *'like'* or *'as'*. It helps readers understand unfamiliar concepts by likening them to familiar ones, often to create vivid imagery.

e.g. My bedroom is like a pigsty. She is as skinny as a rake.

Metaphor

A metaphor is an implied comparison that states one thing is another, thereby transferring qualities from one to the other. Metaphors can make writing more persuasive by enhancing imagery and emotional appeal.

e.g. I stepped into my pigsty, shut the door and climbed into bed. He is a pillar of strength.

Rhetorical Questions

These are questions posed for effect rather than to elicit an answer. They imply that the answer is self-evident, guiding the audience to agree with the writer's point.

e.g. Do you want to see your wife and children out on the streets in rags? Of course you don't!

Scapegoats

A scapegoat is a person or group blamed for something they are not truly responsible for. This technique simplifies complex issues and focuses the reader's anger on a convenient target.

e.g. All our crime and unemployment problems are because of the government.

Assumptions

Assumptions involve treating beliefs or opinions as facts without proof. These are often subtle and can influence readers by appealing to what is generally believed to be true.

e.g. He must be smart because he is on the computer every day.

Presumptions

Presumptions occur when statements are accepted as truths without critical examination. They appeal to common beliefs or cultural norms.

e.g. If it's natural, it's good for you.

Analogy

An analogy compares two things that are alike in some respects to clarify a point or persuade readers that what applies to one must apply to the other.

e.g. If birds can fly because they have wings, then maybe if we develop mechanical wings we can fly too.

e.g. The human brain is like a computer.

Expert Opinion

This technique involves citing someone perceived to have authority or expertise on a topic. It lends credibility to an argument and can be persuasive even if the "expert" is unnamed.

e.g. In the thirty-five years I was Head Surgeon at…

Case Studies and Anecdotes

Case studies and anecdotes are used to personalise or humanise an argument. Anecdotes are usually emotive and personal; case studies more formal and factual. Both aim to build credibility and emotional appeal.

e.g. Pool fencing should be mandatory because my neighbour's child drowned in an unfenced pool.

Empty Truths

Also known as tautologies, these are statements that repeat the same idea unnecessarily, often sounding meaningful but lacking substance.

e.g. Boys will be boys. Enough is enough. Business is business.

Cause and Effect

This technique suggests that one event directly causes another. It is persuasive because it offers logical explanation, though causality may not always be valid.

e.g. Peter crashed his car. Peter died.

Ends and Means / Means to an End

This approach justifies an action based on the outcome, even if the action itself is questionable.

e.g. A criminal donates to a playground; the donation is good, but the source of funds is illegal.

Consequence of a Fact

This presents a pragmatic response to an existing situation by arguing that something should be done simply because a condition exists.

e.g. Nuclear power exists, so we might as well use it.

Judging an Action by its Consequences

This technique justifies or condemns an action based on its results. It focuses on outcomes rather than intent.

e.g. Stealing from the rich to give to the poor is acceptable because the poor are hungry.

Sweeping Statements / Generalisations

These make broad claims that apply to a group without considering individual differences. Generalisations can sound convincing but often oversimplify.

e.g. All teenagers are irresponsible.

Cliché

Clichés are overused phrases that offer familiar shortcuts to meaning. Though persuasive due to their recognisability, they can also weaken writing if not used purposefully.

e.g. What goes around comes around.

Co-existence

This assumes an automatic relationship between ideas or traits, such as assuming someone is good simply because they attend church.

e.g. She goes to the local church, so she must be a good person.

Guilt by Association

This technique links people, ideas or groups with undesirable individuals or arguments in order to discredit them.

e.g. Premier Kennett has behaved like Hitler since coming to power.

Questioning Motive

This involves undermining an argument by questioning the motives of the speaker, diverting attention away from the argument itself.

e.g. The Health Minister's decision to close the hospital is just an excuse to build a monument to himself.

Figures and Statistics

Numbers and data are used to give the illusion of objectivity and reliability. However, the reader must critically assess source, sample size, relevance, and interpretation.

e.g. 300 people died on our roads last year…

Discredit Another Argument

This technique aims to dismantle opposing viewpoints by exposing flaws or inconsistencies in them. It draws attention away from the original argument and weakens the opposing side's credibility.

Attack

This technique involves criticising or mocking opposing arguments or individuals. It is designed to weaken the opposition's credibility and make their position less persuasive. Writers may use name-calling, ridicule, or other personal attacks to influence the audience's perception.

One form of attack is labelling the opposition in an attempt to belittle them.

Flattery and Praise

This technique involves listing individuals or groups who agree with the writer's position in a positive light. By using terms that convey admiration or respect, the writer bolsters the authority of their own argument.

e.g. "Leading scientists support this research."

Use of Punctuation and Printing Style

Writers use punctuation and formatting deliberately to add emphasis, create subtext, or manipulate tone and flow.

Common strategies include:

- Inverted commas – suggest doubt or irony, even when quoting.
- Exclamation marks – show emotional emphasis or urgency.
- Dashes – indicate pauses, hesitation or parenthetical ideas.
- Long sentences – may signal sophistication or rambling.
- Short sentences – create punch, pace and immediacy.

- Italics, CAPITALISATION, **bold**, *underlining* – all used for emphasis.

Vocabulary Use

The choice of vocabulary significantly affects tone and credibility. Writers use sophisticated or precise word choice to sound more authoritative or to target specific reader emotions. Students should be aware of:

- Emotive connotations (e.g. *slaughter* vs *kill*)
- Word strength and subtlety (e.g. *sporadic* vs *occasional*)
- Replacing vague or weak terms with more accurate or academic language.

Improving vocabulary can enhance clarity and persuasiveness. For example:

- Replace “straight away” with “immediately”
- Replace “in the next paragraph” with “in the following section”
- Replace “always” with “consistently”

Table of Common Persuasive Techniques

Persuasive Techniques Reference Table

Persuasive Technique	Definition	How It Persuades
Adjective	Describing words usually connected to a noun (naming word). e.g. *The bright red house* (bright and red = adjectives; house = noun)	Adds emphasis.
Alliteration	Repeating and playing upon the same letter. e.g. *A back-breaking job...*	Adds emphasis and reinforces meaning, especially where an idea is repeated. Often used to create a highly emotive image.
Anecdote	A short account or story of an entertaining or interesting	Usually makes reader sympathetic and receptive to the point; can set up a character, then position reader to

Persuasive Technique	Definition	How It Persuades
	incident. e.g. *In my experience...*	accept or reject that individual character.
Associations	Words that create meanings beyond the literal meaning of the word. e.g. *attractive, alluring, pleasing, charming*	Suggests or influences reader response in certain ways, often subconsciously. Implied meanings need to be identified.
Attacks/praise	The writer attacks or praises an opponent or idea. This is really an assertion of the writer's viewpoint. e.g. *denigrating or humiliating the person, discrediting opponents as unreliable, dishonest, suggesting unsatisfactory associations*	Often effective in placing the reader in a position of agreement with the writer/speaker through forceful language and insistent claims, even without evidence.
Bias	One-sidedness in presentation of view/opinion. e.g. *Eminem's tour promoter obviously sees no danger in what Eminem says.*	Can subjectively influence the reader by intentionally only presenting one side of the argument.
Clichés	Worn out, overused expressions. e.g. *Fit as a fiddle, Turn over a new leaf, Pushing the envelope*	Are familiar, often colloquial, so can offer a shortcut to convey meaning.
Colourful words and descriptive language	Words that are heightened, vivid, lively, and full of interest. e.g. *Hot = blistering, sultry, muggy, suffocating...*	Produce a picture and/or induce an emotion. Engage reader by gaining attention and often put a new slant on familiar events and issues.
Contention	The main line of argument in a text. A statement of the main idea being argued or debated. Focuses on WHAT is being argued.	Pinpoints the issue and the writer's point of view. Helps the reader identify the issue and evaluate the techniques used to persuade them to agree.

Persuasive Technique	Definition	How It Persuades
Emotional Appeals	Play on people's emotions such as fears, insecurities, hopes, desires, and values. Can target: • A sense of justice or injustice • Family values • Tradition or custom • Patriotism • Moral values	Frequently appeal to our values and attitudes, sometimes subtly. Can manipulate reader to take notice of issues by triggering emotional responses.
Emotive Language	The deliberate use of strong emotive words to play on reader's feelings. e.g. *sleazy, slimy, vicious, disgusting, outrageous*	Evokes strong emotional response to coerce or force agreement. Used to stimulate strong emotional reactions and manipulate responses.
Loaded Words (Labelling)	Words that are loaded with associations. e.g. *capitalist, communist, salesman*	Shorthand way of discrediting or praising by suggesting associations. Exploits emotional baggage of such words to sway opinion.
Repetition	Repeated words, phrases, sentence patterns, ideas.	Gives emphasis and prominence to a point or idea; reinforces and makes reader remember the point.
Rhetorical Questions	Questions that have the answer embedded in them; often use irony.	Manipulate the reader to agree because the answer is assumed. Disagreement would mean dismissing a point that commands agreement.
Tone	Refers to the voice of the writer; the writer's attitude to the subject and reader. Tone can be emotive. e.g. *angry, sympathetic, sarcastic*	Reflects writer's attitude, which can influence the reader to agree or reject. Tone can signal a new direction or perspective in the writing.

Table of Verbs for Authorial Intent

Verbs Indicating Authorial Intent

Positive Verbs	Neutral Verbs (“say”, “suggest”)	Subtle Verbs (“imply”, “elicit”)	Negative Verbs
Encourage	Suggest	Insinuate	Condemn
Endorse	Foreground	Reveal	Criticise
Support	Emphasise	Illuminate	Critique
Laud	Highlight	Hint	Attack
Celebrate	Illustrate	Infer	Undermine
Extol	Delineate	Intimate	Contest
Inspire	Showcase	Allude	Refute
Praise	Underscore	Elucidate	Provoke
Applaud	Explore	Evoke	Galvanise
Commend	Express	Engender	Vilify
Venerate	Assert	Invite	Disparage
Glorify	Demonstrate	Induce	Belittle
Elevate	Propose	Explicate	Scorn
Bolster	Announce	Interpret	Censure
Exalt	Declare	Clarify	Castigate
Glamorise	Portray	Exemplify	Reprimand
Reinforce	Depict	Characterise	Harangue
–	Convey	Resolve	Denigrate

Table of Adjectives Describing Tone

Tone Reference Table

Happy Tones	Sad Tones	Angry Tones	Humorous Tones	Neutral Tones
Light-hearted	Disappointed	Accusatory	Satirical	Formal
Hopeful	Shameful	Condescending	Cynical	Matter-of-fact
Elated	Resigned	Aggressive	Taunting	Informative
Enthusiastic	Sympathetic	Disgusted	Facetious	Reflective
Optimistic	Bleak	Incredulous	Amused	Contemplative
Encouraging	Sombre	Demeaning	Animated	Apprehensive

Table of Linking Words and Phrases

Linking Words and Phrases Reference Table

Points of Comparison	Points of Difference	Points of Causality
Also	Conflictingly	Consequently
Likewise	In contrast	As a result
Equally	Contrastingly	Because of this
Synonymously	Contrarily	Thus
Analogously	Unlike	Hence
Akin	Nonetheless	Therefore
Just as	A point of disparity	Ultimately
So too	Conversely	Inevitably
Similarly	Counter to	Accordingly
Furthermore	Contradictorily to	Ergo
Moreover	Opposed to	As a consequence
In the same sense	Inversely	This leads to
–	Alternatively	In turn

Points of Comparison	Points of Difference	Points of Causality
–	However	In light of this
–	Although	Given that
–	On the other hand	Since
–	Despite this	This culminates
Yet	–	This foreshadows
Whereas	–	For that reason
Incongruously	–	This is a repercussion of

Persuasive Techniques Reference (printable)

The full reference table — techniques, definitions, examples and intended effects — as a document you can view or print.

Analysing Visual Language

Many students find the analysis of images an accessible and enjoyable part of Year 12 English. It is important, however, to prepare for a variety of visual elements that may appear on your Unit 3 SAC task on analysing argument, as well as on Section C of the end-of-year examination. Below are some elements to keep an eye out for.

Context and Position

In order to fully understand the meaning of the visual elements in a text, you need to understand the context. Be sure to read any background information accompanying the task so that you know what the main issue is. Both the background information and the written material will help give you a sense of the visual's purpose.

Remember that the focus of Area of Study 2 in the Unit 3 SAC and in Section C of the exam is on the analysis of argument. Noticing where and why a visual element is placed in the written piece can help you to tackle the idea of how the argument is structured.

- Is the visual at the start of the article to elicit empathy or shock?
- Is it in the middle to reinforce a particular piece of evidence or reason?
- Is it at the end to consolidate the argument as a whole?
- Is it a frame or border to the written piece that contributes to the overall approach and tone?
- Alternatively, if the visual is a completely separate text from the written piece, does it present the same or a different point of view on the issue?

Ask yourself: where is the visual positioned and why does it matter?

Colour and Design Elements

Although the task material for Section C of the exam will be printed in black and white, your Unit 3 SAC might well contain colour images. If this is the case, you can certainly explore the mood that is created by the use of colour, as well as any relevant connotations of the colour scheme. In a black-and-white image it is possible to discuss degrees of shading and how these affect meaning.

It is important to remember that visual language can pertain to design elements in the text you are analysing. For example, in the task material for Section C of the VCAA sample exam the speaker's first slide has illustrations incorporated into the year '2010'. The embedded images of fish, a flamingo, waves, a tree, and an adult and child holding hands help to promote the speaker's arguments about the beauty of biodiversity and humanity's central involvement in its protection.

Also be alert to the design elements of internet text types such as web pages and blogs. You can, for example, discuss the use of icons, how they position the viewer and the symbolism embedded in them.

Ask yourself: how do design elements, colour and/or shading of the visual contribute to its meaning?



1. The colours are relatively bright considering the seriousness of the issue. This is an example of how a cartoonist can engage an audience through colour and light, making a complex or confronting issue more accessible.
2. The text in the speech bubbles uses irony to comment on how the army tank is affecting the petrol tank.
3. The placement and size of the tank immediately draws the eye to it; the car and the petrol bowser are less prominent. This could be a comment on the scale of the effects the conflict was having on the world at this time.
4. The large, rugged tank is juxtaposed with the small, bright blue car. This contrast may reflect the serious nature of the war and what the soldiers are enduring, in comparison to the everyday lives of people far from the conflict.
5. The tank has driven over the fuel hose, providing a metaphor for the way in which the Ukrainian conflict is creating difficulties for people in Australia.

Insight Example Image Analysis

Cartoons

Cartoons often accompany an opinion piece; they can also be stand-alone texts offering a viewpoint on a current issue – especially one that involves politicians or high-profile figures. To understand a cartoon it can be important to have an understanding of the issues circulating in the media in any given week. As I write, there are two quite different

cartoons in The Age and The Australian that contain an image of a whiteboard, among other elements. To make sense of both cartoons, a reader would need to know that earlier in the week security guards in Parliament House used a whiteboard to shield a politician from photographers and journalists. Without this knowledge it would be difficult, if not impossible, to interpret the cartoons. Try to stay informed about current affairs as you practise analysing media texts, so that you can grasp their full meanings.

Cartoons tend to exaggerate the features of those they represent and use minimal – often quite pithy – text. Be mindful of where this text is: does it appear in a speech bubble or balloon and therefore represent a person's thoughts or speech? Or is the text elsewhere – on a sign, say, or framed as a caption – providing additional context or comment?

The tone of a cartoon is an important feature to note. Political cartoons in particular are often sarcastic and position the reader to be critical of politicians and/or their views and policies.

Ask yourself: how does the cartoon make me feel? Your response will give you a guide to the tone of this visual.

Photographs

Photographs can provide a wealth of material for analysis. Look for a range of elements, including:

- whether the shot is low-angle (looking up at the subject), high-angle (looking down on the subject) or straight-on – for example, a low-angle shot of a child might give the impression that they have been able to overcome adversity and achieve success, whereas a high-angle shot might suggest that a person is vulnerable or remorseful
- whether the subject is in the foreground (making them very prominent) or background (emphasising their context)
- whether elements of the photograph are blurred or in soft focus
- whether a filter (e.g. warm or cool) is used
- where the horizon is placed in a landscape shot (e.g. far away can signal isolation or opportunity)
- what is actually in the frame (mise en scène) and what might have been left out

- whether a text overlay has been used and how that frames your reading of the photograph.

Ask yourself: What would the impact be if I changed an element of the photograph (e.g. camera angle or focus)? Answering this question will give you better insight into what the photograph is intending to achieve.

Charts and Diagrams

Charts and diagrams containing numerical information can be used to present evidence. Although you are not in a position to question the data, you can explore how the information and its visual presentation are used to strengthen and develop an argument. It is good to watch for:

- what the visual elements suggest and how they connect to each other
- whether a background image can be seen beneath a written overlay (e.g. an image of a gun beneath statistics about the number of deaths caused by shooting)
- whether data is attributed to an authority (such as the Australian Bureau of Statistics). Sometimes charts and diagrams can look dry and intimidating.

Ask yourself:how does the information relate to the written text or texts? Does it support or contradict a written text and, if so, how?

Concluding Remarks

For the Exam, it is imperative that you compare the written and visual material supplied. It is also wise to compare the written and visual texts in the examination. Comparing written and visual material in terms of the arguments they present and the ways in which they position the audience will give your analysis more depth and cohesion, and demonstrate a stronger understanding of each.



Section C image from 2024 VCAA English Exam

Practice Articles for Analysis

Four practice tasks in the format of Section C of the English exam. Each one has its own instructions, task and background information, followed by the persuasive text and its visual. Allow about an hour for each: roughly five minutes planning, 50 minutes writing and five minutes proofreading. The people, places, publications and survey figures in these tasks are fictional.

Scenario 1: Backyard hens

Section C – Analysis of argument and language

Instructions

- In this section, you are required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen persuasive text.
- Read the background information below and the material that follows, and write an analytical response to the task.
- For the purposes of this task, the term ‘language’ refers to written and spoken language, and ‘visuals’ refers to images and graphics.
- This section is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.

Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

The Greenhill Gazette is a free monthly newsletter that is delivered to every home in the small country town of Greenhill. Local clubs and community groups often use the newsletter to share news and information with residents. The following article was written by Margaret Kovac, who has been the secretary of the Greenhill Poultry Club for more than ten years.

Before you bring home the girls: a few honest words about backyard hens



By Margaret Kovac

Over the last few years it seems like every second backyard in Greenhill has a chook pen in it. When I joined the Greenhill Poultry Club eleven years ago, we had nine members and most of us had grey hair. Today we have over sixty, and plenty of them are young families who have never looked after anything bigger than a goldfish. I think that's wonderful. I also think it's time someone said a few things that don't make it into the lovely photos on Instagram.

First, the good news. Hens are funny, friendly little creatures, and they'll happily follow you around the garden in case you've got something for them. A healthy hen will give you four or five eggs a week in her best years, and there is nothing quite like a fresh egg with a deep orange yolk on a Sunday morning. Hens will eat your vegetable scraps (which means less going in the bin), scratch out the weeds and turn the whole lot into some of the best fertiliser you'll ever put on your garden. Kids love them. So do grandparents.

So what's the catch?

A chook is not a kitchen appliance

I've lost count of the number of times someone has rung me in March asking if the club can 'take' their hens. Usually the story is the same. The family bought three young pullets in spring, the kids named them, everyone was very excited – and then winter

came, the eggs slowed down and suddenly nobody wanted to go out to the pen at six o'clock in the dark and the rain.

Here's something those videos don't tell you: a hen can live for eight years or more, but most only lay well for the first two or three. After that you have a pet that eats, needs cleaning up after and gives you very little back. If you aren't prepared to look after her for the long haul, please don't get her in the first place. Just like a dog, a hen is a commitment, not a weekend project.

Do your homework

Before you buy anything, ring Greenhill Shire Council or have a look at their website. There are rules about how many birds you can keep (in most residential streets here the limit is six), how far the pen has to be from your neighbour's fence and, yes, roosters are a firm no in town. Nobody wants to be the reason the whole street gets woken up at 4.45 am.

You'll also need to think about:

- a proper fox-proof pen with a roof (foxes are out at dusk and they are a lot cleverer than you'd think)
- somewhere dry and sealed for the feed, because if you leave pellets lying around you'll soon have rats as well as chickens
- who will feed and water them when you go away at Christmas
- what happens when one of them gets sick – and they do.

Not many vets in our area will see poultry, so it pays to find out which ones do before you need them.

What will it really cost?

People often tell me they're getting chooks to save money on eggs. I hate to be the one to break it to you, but that's not how it works – at least not at first. A decent fox-proof coop will set you back anywhere from $400 to well over $1000 (the cheap flat-pack ones from online shops tend to fall apart after a winter or two – ask me how I know). Then there's the feeder, the waterer, straw or wood shavings for bedding, worming and lice treatments, and of course the feed itself. Three hens will get through a 20-kilogram bag of layer pellets about every five or six weeks, and that's around $35 a bag at the produce store on Main Street at the moment.

When one of our members, Danny, sat down and did the sums on his first year, he worked out that each of his eggs had cost him about $1.40. He had a good laugh about it at our March meeting, and to be fair to Danny, he still says it's the best money he's ever spent. But go in knowing the numbers.

Have a word with the neighbours

This one costs nothing at all. Before the pen goes up, pop next door and let them know what you're planning. Most people are happy to have hens nearby, especially if there's the odd half-dozen eggs coming their way over the fence. What they don't like is finding out from the smell on a hot day in January.

Keep it clean

Chickens can carry salmonella even when they look perfectly healthy. That doesn't mean you should panic, but it does mean washing your hands every time you've handled them or their eggs, keeping the pen away from where little ones play and not letting the birds wander through the kitchen (I've seen it happen!). Cuddling is fine. Kissing is not.

The rewards are real

I don't want to put anyone off. Some of my happiest hours are spent sitting on an upturned bucket with a cup of tea, watching my girls have a dust bath in the sun. My granddaughter collects the eggs every Saturday and writes the totals on a chart on our fridge – last year we got to 1104. Keeping hens has taught her more about where her food comes from than any school excursion ever could.

But the families who get the most out of it are the ones who go in with their eyes open. They've done the planning, they've spent a bit more on a good pen than they really wanted to, and they know what they're signing up for.

Come and have a chat

If you're thinking about getting hens, the Greenhill Poultry Club meets on the first Sunday of every month at the Scout Hall on Pine Street from 10 am. Bring your questions, have a look at some of our members' set-ups and maybe even hold a chook or two before you make up your mind. Membership is $20 a year and the scones are free.

Do it once and do it right – your hens will thank you for it.

Scenario 2: Mending, not hauling

Section C – Analysis of argument and language

Instructions

- In this section, you are required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen persuasive text.

- Read the background information below and the material that follows, and write an analytical response to the task.
- For the purposes of this task, the term ‘language’ refers to written and spoken language, and ‘visuals’ refers to images and graphics.
- This section is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.

Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

Buying second-hand clothes from op shops and online marketplaces has become very popular, and many people share videos of their ‘hauls’ (large amounts of clothing bought in one trip) on social media. Second Stitch is a small clothing repair and alterations studio in the coastal town of Kestrel Bay. Its owner, Jonah Petrakis, posts short videos about mending clothes and has a large online following. The text below is the transcript of one of his videos. The image is the video’s thumbnail.



Why your thrift haul might be part of the problem

Second Stitch

Hey everyone, Jonah here from Second Stitch. Before we get into today's video, can I just say thank you – we hit 40,000 followers last week, which is honestly a bit mad for a guy who sews patches onto jeans in a shop the size of a garage. So, thank you.

Okay. Today I want to talk about something that's been bugging me for a while, and I know some of you aren't going to love it.

Hauls.

You know the videos. Someone goes to the op shop, or onto one of the second-hand apps, and comes home with five or six bags of stuff. They hold everything up to the camera one at a time and say, 'I don't know if I'll actually wear this, but it was only five dollars!' And everyone in the comments goes, 'Love this, so sustainable!'

I used to make those videos. I'm not going to pretend I didn't.

But here's what changed my mind. About a year ago a woman came into the shop with a coat. A beautiful old wool coat that had belonged to her dad – probably fifty years old. One of the pockets had ripped away and the lining was gone at the elbows. It took me about three hours to fix, and when she picked it up she cried. Actually cried. And I remember thinking, when was the last time anything in one of my hauls made somebody feel like that?

Look, second-hand is better than new. I'm not arguing with that. Every piece of clothing that gets worn again is one less that ends up in landfill, and one less that has to be made from scratch with all the water and energy and dye that goes into it. But buying second-hand in bulk is still buying in bulk. If the clothes come home, get worn once for the video and then go back in a bag to the charity bin, we haven't really changed anything. We've just made fast fashion a little bit slower.

And the op shops know it. I spoke to a volunteer at one of the big charity shops in town (she asked me not to say which one) and she told me they now have to throw out a huge amount of what gets donated because it's ripped, stained or just too cheaply made to sell. A lot of it was only bought a few months ago. Some of it still has the tags on.

I ran a quick poll on my stories last week and, I'll be honest, the results surprised me. I asked how many of you had bought something second-hand in the last month and never worn it. Just over half of you said yes. Fifty-three per cent! And I'm guessing a few more of you weren't game to admit it.

A lot of you also sent me messages after my last video, and one question kept coming up, so I want to answer it properly. It came from a follower called Tash, who said – and I'm quoting here – 'Easy for you to say, you can sew. I can't afford to pay someone forty bucks to fix a $10 shirt.'

Tash, that's fair. Really, it is. Not everything is worth fixing, and I would never tell anyone to spend money they don't have. But a few things. First, most repairs are a lot cheaper than people think – a button or a small tear is usually under ten dollars at my shop, and I'm not the cheapest in town. Second, if a $10 shirt isn't worth fixing, maybe it wasn't worth buying either? I know, I know. That one stings a bit. And third, you don't have to pay anyone at all if you learn to do it yourself, which brings me to the actual point of this video.

So what do I actually want you to do? Three things, and they're pretty easy.

One: before you buy anything, new or old, ask yourself if you'd still want it if it cost full price. If the answer is no, leave it on the rack for someone who actually needs it.

Two: learn one repair. Just one. Sewing a button back on takes about four minutes and I've got a video on it – I'll put the link below. Once you've done that, try a simple hem or a patch. Honestly, it gets kind of addictive.

Three: if something's beyond you, take it to someone who can fix it. That doesn't have to be me! There are alteration shops all over the place and most of them are doing it tough because nobody gets things repaired any more. A new zip in a pair of jeans you love costs about the same as a cheap new pair, and the old ones will last you years longer.

Every second Saturday we run a free Repair Café at the Kestrel Bay library. You bring the clothes, we bring the sewing machines, and we'll show you how to do it yourself. Last month we fixed sixty-two things in one afternoon, including a wedding dress and a very sad-looking teddy bear. Our oldest volunteer, Doreen, is eighty-one and has been sewing since she was eight. She will tell you, very kindly, that you're doing it wrong. She'll also be right.

I'm not saying never go shopping again. I still love a good op shop find. I'm just asking you to buy a bit less, keep things a bit longer and fix them when they break. Your wardrobe will thank you, your bank account will thank you, and so will the planet.

Anyway, that's my rant for the week. Show me your best repair in the comments – I want to see them all! See you next time.

Scenario 3: Regional trains

Section C – Analysis of argument and language

Instructions

- In this section, you are required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen persuasive text.
- Read the background information below and the material that follows, and write an analytical response to the task.
- For the purposes of this task, the term ‘language’ refers to written and spoken language, and ‘visuals’ refers to images and graphics.
- This section is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.

Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

Westmere is a regional town about 150 kilometres from Melbourne, and many of its residents travel to the city by train for work, study and medical appointments. In recent years there have been many complaints about delays and cancellations on the line. The Westmere Courier is the local newspaper, and each week it publishes letters from readers. The following letter was written by Priya Raman, a nurse who commutes to a Melbourne hospital. The graph was printed beside the letter and was supplied by the Westmere Rail Users Group, a volunteer group that represents passengers.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

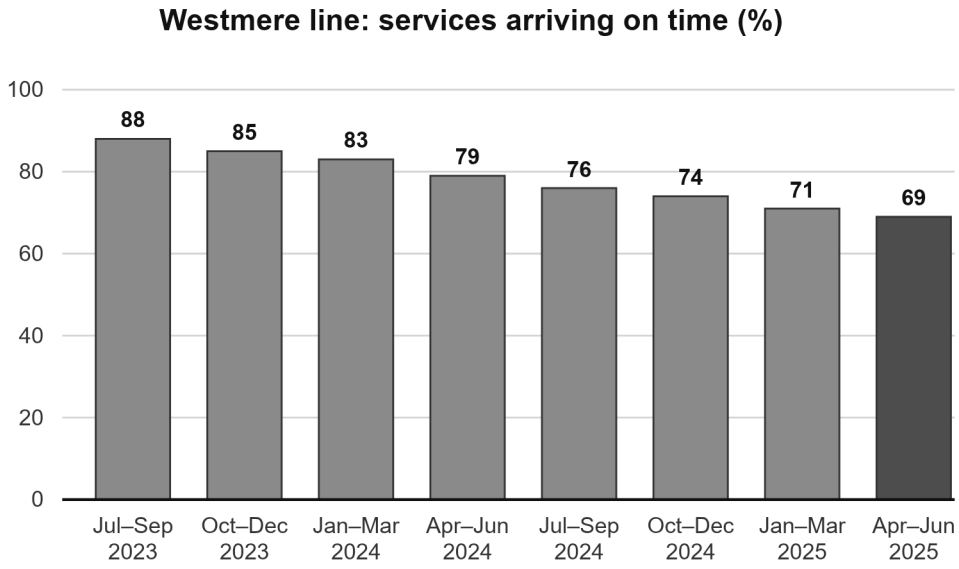
We deserve a train we can count on

Last Tuesday I sat on the 6.12 am train from Westmere for an hour and forty minutes. The trip is meant to take an hour and five. Somewhere outside Darrow we stopped for ‘signal faults’ and stayed there long enough for the man across the aisle to finish his crossword, eat his lunch at half past seven in the morning and fall asleep. I got to the hospital fifty minutes late for a twelve-hour shift, on a ward that was already two nurses short.

This is not unusual. This is a normal week.

I have caught this train for nine years. When I started, it was something you could set your watch by. You’d get the odd delay in a heatwave, and everyone understood that. Now I leave home with no real idea of when I’ll get to work, or whether my train will turn up at all. My colleagues who travel from Ardley and Hollins say exactly the same thing.

Last month I got talking to a young woman on the platform at Westmere called Ella. She's in the second year of a nursing degree (I told her she was mad, and she laughed). Because of cancellations, she has missed two of her hospital placement days this year, and the university has told her that if it happens again she may have to repeat the whole unit. So now she gets up at 4.30 to catch an earlier train 'just in case', which gets her into the city two hours before she needs to be there, sitting in a café she can't really afford. She is nineteen. She should not have to plan her whole life around a train that may or may not come.



Source: Westmere Rail Users Group. 'On time' = within five minutes of the timetable.

The figures back this up. The Westmere Rail Users Group has been keeping track of every service on our line since 2023, and you can see the results on this page. In the middle of 2023, nearly nine out of every ten trains arrived on time. By the middle of this year it was fewer than seven. That means on any given day, roughly one in three of us is late – for work, for school, for medical appointments, for the job interview we spent weeks getting ready for.

And it isn't only delays. On eleven mornings so far this year my train has been cancelled outright and a coach sent instead – a coach that takes nearly two hours, has no toilet and stops in every town along the way. Try explaining that to the patient whose dressing was meant to be changed at 7.30, or to the night-shift nurse who has been waiting to go home since seven.

Some people will say, well, just drive. I've done the sums on that too. A return trip to Melbourne is about 300 kilometres. Between petrol, tolls and parking near the hospital (which is $28 a day if you're lucky enough to find a spot), driving would cost me close to $90 a day – about $350 for a normal four-shift week. That's before you even think about wear and tear on the car, or what it's like to drive home down the highway after a night shift with your eyes closing. My train ticket costs a fraction of that. When it actually runs,

the train is the cheapest, safest and most sensible way for people like me to get to work. That is exactly why it matters so much when it doesn't.

We are told the problem is 'ageing infrastructure'. I don't doubt it. Parts of the track past Darrow were laid before my grandparents were born, and the signals are so old that replacement parts have to be specially made. But none of this is news. A state government review pointed out these problems back in 2019, and since then we have had plenty of announcements and very little actual work.

Meanwhile, the city lines have had their new tunnels, their new stations and their shiny new trains. Good on them. I don't begrudge anyone a better trip to work. But it is hard not to feel that people out here are an afterthought – that because there are fewer of us, our time somehow matters less.

It does matter. When the train fails, people drive instead, and anyone who has been on the highway at 7 am lately knows how well that's going. Young people who can't rely on getting to uni or TAFE in the city end up moving away, and most of them don't come back. Local businesses lose staff. At my hospital, three nurses from this part of the state have resigned in the past year, and at least two of them told me the train was a big part of the reason. When a ward is already short-staffed, that is not a small thing. And those of us who don't have a choice – who can't afford a second car, or who don't drive – are simply left standing on the platform.

I am not asking for the impossible. I am asking for the track and signal upgrades we were promised six years ago, with a real start date and a real budget. I am asking for honest information on the app, so I'm not standing on a freezing platform watching the departure time change three times. And I am asking our local member, who I notice drives to Melbourne, to come and catch the 6.12 with me one morning and see what it's like.

I'll even save you a seat. If the train turns up.

Priya Raman, Westmere

Scenario 4: Study apps

Section C – Analysis of argument and language

Instructions

- In this section, you are required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen

persuasive text.

- Read the background information below and the material that follows, and write an analytical response to the task.
- For the purposes of this task, the term ‘language’ refers to written and spoken language, and ‘visuals’ refers to images and graphics.
- This section is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.

Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

Many students now use apps to help them study, including flashcard and quiz apps, maths practice programs and AI tutors. Northcliff Secondary College recently held an information evening for parents of students in Years 9 and 10. One of the guest speakers was Dr Helena Varga, a psychologist who works with teenagers and their families. The text below is a transcript of part of her speech. The image is one of the slides she showed during her talk.

Are study apps really helping our kids learn?

Dr Helena Varga

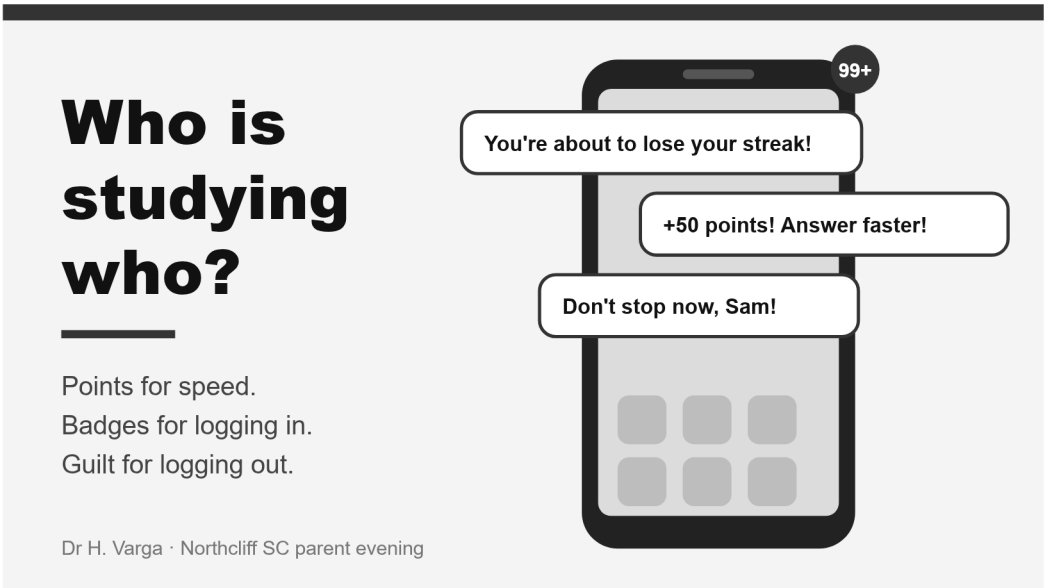
Good evening, everyone, and thank you for having me. I know it’s a cold night and the footy’s on, so I really appreciate you coming out.

I’d like to start with a quick show of hands. Who here has a child who uses some kind of study app? Flashcards, quiz games, maths practice, one of the new AI tutors? Yes – that’s nearly all of you. Now keep your hand up if you’ve ever sat down and used that app yourself for twenty minutes. Not so many. That’s okay. I hadn’t either, until a couple of years ago.

I got interested because of a Year 10 boy I was seeing – I’ll call him Sam. Sam’s mum was worried because his marks had dropped, even though he was ‘studying’ for three hours every night. And it was true, he was. His study app showed a streak of 211 days. He had badges, he had trophies, he was in the top league of some leaderboard. What he didn’t have was much memory of the work. When I asked him to explain a topic he had ‘completed’ the week before, he couldn’t do it.

So I did what any nosy psychologist would do. I downloaded the app.

Within about ten minutes I understood. Every few seconds something flashed, buzzed or congratulated me. I got points for being fast, not for being right. When I tried to close it, a little cartoon character popped up to tell me I was about to ‘lose my streak’. I felt guilty! And I’m forty-seven years old.



Here’s what we need to understand as parents. A lot of these apps are made by the same kinds of companies, using the same kinds of tricks, as the social media and games we already spend so much energy worrying about. They’re designed to keep our kids on them for as long as possible, because that’s how they make their money – through subscriptions, through ads, or through the data they collect. Keeping a teenager on a screen and helping a teenager learn are two very different goals. When they clash, I’m afraid you can probably guess which one wins.

Real learning is a bit slow and a bit uncomfortable. It’s sitting with a hard problem and not knowing the answer for a while. It’s trying to remember something without being handed three multiple-choice options. Researchers sometimes call this ‘desirable difficulty’, and it’s exactly what most of these apps are built to take away, because difficulty makes people put the phone down.

And the AI tutors are a whole new level again. I’ve watched students type a homework question in, copy the answer out neatly and feel very pleased with themselves. The work is done. Nothing has gone into their heads.

Last year our clinic ran a small trial with two Year 10 classes at a local school. One class used a popular quiz app for their revision; the other used paper flashcards and tested each other in pairs. After six weeks, the app class had actually spent more time studying – about forty minutes more each week. But the paper class scored, on average, eleven

per cent higher on the end-of-term test. It was a small trial and I wouldn't build a whole school policy on it. But it fits with what I see in my office every single week.

Now, I know what some of you are thinking, because a dad put his hand up and said it to me at a school very much like this one last term. He said, 'With respect, Doctor, at least they're doing something. If my daughter's not on the study app, she's on TikTok.'

It's a fair point, and I want to take it seriously. If the choice really is between a quiz app and three hours of endless scrolling, then yes, the quiz app probably wins. But I don't think that's the real choice most of the time. The trouble is that the app gives us, the parents, the feeling that the job is being done. We walk past the bedroom, we see the colourful screen and the little trophies, and we relax. These apps are very good at convincing us, as well as our kids, that learning is happening – and that feeling is exactly what these companies are selling. In my experience it can stop us from asking the harder questions, like 'What did you actually learn tonight?' or 'Can you show me?'

I'm not here to tell you to throw the phones in the river. Some apps are genuinely useful, and some kids really do need them. What I'm asking is that we stop assuming that time spent on a 'study' app is time spent learning.

So, a few practical suggestions:

- Turn off the notifications. All of them. The app will still be there when your child decides to open it.
- Ask your child to teach you what they learnt today, without the screen. If they can, great. If they can't, that tells you something.
- Keep at least some study old-fashioned: pen, paper, a textbook and a timer.
- Find out what the app actually collects. Sit down with your child, go into the settings and have a look together – you might both be surprised.
- And – this is the hard one – model it. If we're scrolling all evening, it's a bit rich to expect them not to.

Sam, by the way, deleted the app in the end. It was a rough fortnight. He lost his 211-day streak and he was not happy with me about it. But his next set of results was the best he'd had all year.

Thank you. I'm happy to take a few questions.

Sample Analysing Argument Essays

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Structure & evidence | Audience positioning | Language & technique | Ideas & interpretation

Sample Analysing Argument Essays

The three responses below were all written for the same task: Scenario 3 on the Practice Articles for Analysis page, a letter to the editor of the *Westmere Courier* by Priya Raman, a nurse who commutes to Melbourne by train. The first sits in the low range, the second in the middle range and the third in the high range. Each one has an introduction, three body paragraphs built around the letter's main arguments, and a conclusion. Read the task and the letter first, then compare how each response handles argument, language, the visual and the audience.

The Task and Letter

The task, background information and letter are reproduced below.

Section C – Analysis of argument and language

Instructions

- In this section, you are required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen persuasive text.
- Read the background information below and the material that follows, and write an analytical response to the task.
- For the purposes of this task, the term 'language' refers to written and spoken language, and 'visuals' refers to images and graphics.

- This section is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.

Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

Westmere is a regional town about 150 kilometres from Melbourne, and many of its residents travel to the city by train for work, study and medical appointments. In recent years there have been many complaints about delays and cancellations on the line. The Westmere Courier is the local newspaper, and each week it publishes letters from readers. The following letter was written by Priya Raman, a nurse who commutes to a Melbourne hospital. The graph was printed beside the letter and was supplied by the Westmere Rail Users Group, a volunteer group that represents passengers.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

We deserve a train we can count on

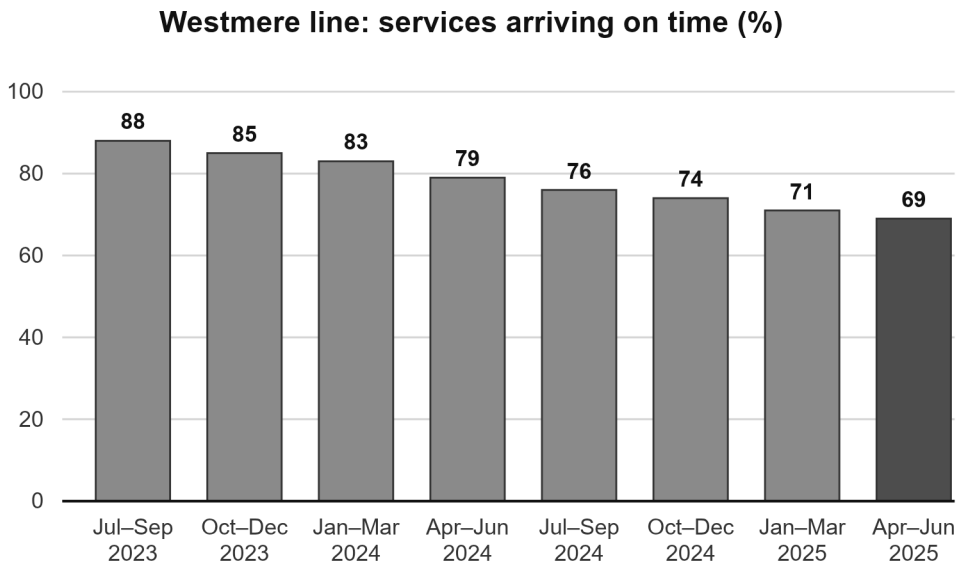
Last Tuesday I sat on the 6.12 am train from Westmere for an hour and forty minutes. The trip is meant to take an hour and five. Somewhere outside Darrow we stopped for ‘signal faults’ and stayed there long enough for the man across the aisle to finish his crossword, eat his lunch at half past seven in the morning and fall asleep. I got to the hospital fifty minutes late for a twelve-hour shift, on a ward that was already two nurses short.

This is not unusual. This is a normal week.

I have caught this train for nine years. When I started, it was something you could set your watch by. You’d get the odd delay in a heatwave, and everyone understood that. Now I leave home with no real idea of when I’ll get to work, or whether my train will turn up at all. My colleagues who travel from Ardley and Hollins say exactly the same thing.

Last month I got talking to a young woman on the platform at Westmere called Ella. She’s in the second year of a nursing degree (I told her she was mad, and she laughed). Because of cancellations, she has missed two of her hospital placement days this year, and the university has told her that if it happens again she may have to repeat the whole unit. So now she gets up at 4.30 to catch an earlier train ‘just in case’, which gets her into the city two hours before she needs to be there, sitting in a café she can’t really

afford. She is nineteen. She should not have to plan her whole life around a train that may or may not come.



Source: Westmere Rail Users Group. 'On time' = within five minutes of the timetable.

The figures back this up. The Westmere Rail Users Group has been keeping track of every service on our line since 2023, and you can see the results on this page. In the middle of 2023, nearly nine out of every ten trains arrived on time. By the middle of this year it was fewer than seven. That means on any given day, roughly one in three of us is late – for work, for school, for medical appointments, for the job interview we spent weeks getting ready for.

And it isn’t only delays. On eleven mornings so far this year my train has been cancelled outright and a coach sent instead – a coach that takes nearly two hours, has no toilet and stops in every town along the way. Try explaining that to the patient whose dressing was meant to be changed at 7.30, or to the night-shift nurse who has been waiting to go home since seven.

Some people will say, well, just drive. I’ve done the sums on that too. A return trip to Melbourne is about 300 kilometres. Between petrol, tolls and parking near the hospital (which is $28 a day if you’re lucky enough to find a spot), driving would cost me close to $90 a day – about $350 for a normal four-shift week. That’s before you even think about wear and tear on the car, or what it’s like to drive home down the highway after a night shift with your eyes closing. My train ticket costs a fraction of that. When it actually runs, the train is the cheapest, safest and most sensible way for people like me to get to work. That is exactly why it matters so much when it doesn’t.

We are told the problem is ‘ageing infrastructure’. I don’t doubt it. Parts of the track past Darrow were laid before my grandparents were born, and the signals are so old that replacement parts have to be specially made. But none of this is news. A state

government review pointed out these problems back in 2019, and since then we have had plenty of announcements and very little actual work.

Meanwhile, the city lines have had their new tunnels, their new stations and their shiny new trains. Good on them. I don't begrudge anyone a better trip to work. But it is hard not to feel that people out here are an afterthought – that because there are fewer of us, our time somehow matters less.

It does matter. When the train fails, people drive instead, and anyone who has been on the highway at 7 am lately knows how well that's going. Young people who can't rely on getting to uni or TAFE in the city end up moving away, and most of them don't come back. Local businesses lose staff. At my hospital, three nurses from this part of the state have resigned in the past year, and at least two of them told me the train was a big part of the reason. When a ward is already short-staffed, that is not a small thing. And those of us who don't have a choice – who can't afford a second car, or who don't drive – are simply left standing on the platform.

I am not asking for the impossible. I am asking for the track and signal upgrades we were promised six years ago, with a real start date and a real budget. I am asking for honest information on the app, so I'm not standing on a freezing platform watching the departure time change three times. And I am asking our local member, who I notice drives to Melbourne, to come and catch the 6.12 with me one morning and see what it's like.

I'll even save you a seat. If the train turns up.

Priya Raman, Westmere

Sample Essay I (Low)

In the letter 'We deserve a train we can count on' written by Priya Raman in the Westmere Courier, she talks about how the trains in Westmere are always late and the government needs to fix it. She is a nurse and she uses alot of persuasive techniques to get the reader to agree with her .

Priya's first argument is that the trains are late and it is affecting people. She uses an anecdote at the start about when her train was late last Tuesday. She says that it took 'an hour and forty minutes' when it is meant to take 'an hour and five'. This is an anecdote and it makes the reader feel sorry for her . She also talks about a man who finished his crossword and ate his lunch and then fell asleep which is funny . Then she says she was 'fifty minutes late' for her shift. This makes the reader feel sympathy because nurses are

important and the hospital was already short of staff . Priya also talks about a girl called Ella who is a nursing student and is nineteen. Ella has missed placement days because of the train. This is another anecdote and it is sad because she is young and has to get up at 4.30 in the morning. The reader will feel bad for Ella.

Priya's second argument is that the trains are getting worse. She uses statistics to show this. The graph shows that the trains arriving on time went from 88 to 69. This is a big drop and it shows the trains are getting worse. She also says 'roughly one in three of us is late'. Statistics are used to make an argument more believable and the reader will believe her because it has numbers. The graph is grey and the last bar is darker then the others . She also uses a rhetorical question when she says 'Some people will say, well, just drive.' This makes the reader think about it. She then says driving would cost 'close to $90 a day' which is alot of money so the reader will agree that driving is not a good idea .

Priya's third argument is that the government does not care about people in Westmere. She compares the city lines to the country lines. The city has 'new tunnels' and 'shiny new trains' and Westmere doesn't get anything. This is unfair and the reader will think the government doesnt care about people in the country . At the end she uses repetition, 'I am asking' three times. Repetition makes the argument stick in the readers head . She also invites the local member to catch the train with her which is a good way to finish. She says 'I'll even save you a seat. If the train turns up.' This is humour and it makes the reader laugh .

In conclusion, Priya Raman uses anecdotes, statistics, a graph and repetition to persuade the reader that the trains in Westmere need to be fixed. She is very persuasive because she is a nurse and she uses lots of different techniques .

Sample Essay II (Medium)

In her letter to the editor of the Westmere Courier, titled 'We deserve a train we can count on', nurse and long-time commuter Priya Raman contends that the state government has neglected the Westmere train line and must commit to the track and signal upgrades it promised. Writing to an audience of mainly Westmere residents, many of whom would also rely on the train, as well as the local member of parliament , Raman uses a frustrated but at times humorous tone to argue that regional passengers are being treated as less important than those in the city.

Raman first argues that the unreliable train service is having a real impact on the people who use it. She begins with a personal anecdote about her trip to work the previous

Tuesday. By describing how she ‘sat on the 6.12 am train from Westmere for an hour and forty minutes’, she immediately places the reader on the train with her . The humorous image of the man across the aisle who was able to ‘finish his crossword, eat his lunch at half past seven in the morning and fall asleep’ exaggerates how long the delay lasted, and the audience are likely to find this amusing but also recognise it from their own experiences. As such, the audience, particularly other commuters, are more inclined to see Raman as one of them and trust her point of view. Raman then reveals that she was ‘fifty minutes late for a twelve-hour shift, on a ward that was already two nurses short’. This shifts the tone from humorous to serious , as the audience start to understand that the delays do not only affect commuters but also the patients who rely on nurses like her. The short sentence ‘This is a normal week’ emphasises how regular these problems have become. Raman also includes the anecdote of Ella, a nineteen-year-old nursing student who now catches an earlier train ‘just in case’. The audience are positioned to feel sympathy for Ella, as she is young and is already being disadvantaged by something she cannot control.

Raman’s second argument is that the service is getting worse and that there is no real alternative to it. She uses the statistics from the Westmere Rail Users Group to show that ‘nearly nine out of every ten trains’ were once on time but now it is ‘fewer than seven’, and that ‘roughly one in three of us is late’. The use of the inclusive pronoun ‘us’ groups Raman together with the audience, encouraging them to see the problem as one that affects the whole community. The accompanying bar graph reinforces this, as each bar is lower than the one before it, showing a steady decline over two years. The final bar is shaded darker than the rest , drawing the reader’s eye to the lowest figure of 69 per cent. As a result, the audience are more likely to accept that the line is getting worse and is not just having a bad week . Raman then anticipates the argument that people should ‘just drive’ instead. She uses logic and statistics to rebut this, calculating that driving would cost her ‘close to $90 a day’, and she appeals to the audience’s sense of safety by describing driving home after a night shift ‘with your eyes closing’. As such, the audience are more likely to agree that the train is the ‘cheapest, safest and most sensible’ option, which makes its unreliability seem even more frustrating.

Finally, Raman argues that regional people are being treated unfairly and that the government needs to act. She explains that the problems were identified ‘back in 2019’ but there has been ‘plenty of announcements and very little actual work’. This makes the government seem as though it only cares about looking like it is doing something, causing the audience to lose trust in their promises . Raman then compares the Westmere line to

the city lines, which have had ‘new tunnels’, ‘new stations’ and ‘shiny new trains’. Although she says ‘Good on them’, the comparison makes the audience feel that regional people are an ‘afterthought’. She then lists the wider consequences for the community, such as young people moving away and nurses resigning from her hospital, which broadens her argument from a personal complaint to a community issue . Raman uses repetition of ‘I am asking’ to set out exactly what she wants, which makes her demands seem reasonable and clear . She ends by challenging the local member to catch the train with her, and the final line ‘If the train turns up’ uses humour to leave the audience with a reminder of how unreliable the service is.

Overall, Priya Raman uses personal anecdotes, statistics, a bar graph and a comparison with the city to persuade the audience that the Westmere line has been neglected. She positions the audience to feel sympathy and frustration, and to support her call for the government to finally upgrade the line.

Sample Essay III (High)

In a letter to the editor of the regional Westmere Courier, nurse Priya Raman contends that the Westmere train line has been left to decline while city commuters enjoy new investment, and that the government must deliver the long-promised track and signal upgrades with ‘a real start date and a real budget’. Her readership is a community that knows the train intimately, and Raman writes less to inform them than to give their shared frustration a shape and a target . Her tone moves from wry, almost weary humour into measured indignation , and finally into a pointed challenge to the local member, so that by the end of the letter a private inconvenience has become a public question of fairness.

Raman’s first argument is that the failing service has real human costs, and she makes this case through story rather than statement. Raman opens not with an argument but with a scene . The 6.12 am train, the ‘signal faults’ outside Darrow and the man who manages to ‘finish his crossword, eat his lunch at half past seven in the morning and fall asleep’ are comic in their detail, and this is a deliberate choice. Humour allows Raman to establish herself as reasonable rather than shrill ; she is laughing at the absurdity before she is angry about it. Yet the joke ends abruptly when she arrives ‘fifty minutes late for a twelve-hour shift, on a ward that was already two nurses short’. The stakes are suddenly raised from a ruined morning to patient care. Her credibility as a nurse is doing quiet work here . She never has to argue that her lateness matters, because the reader already understands what a short-staffed ward means. The two blunt sentences that follow, ‘This is not unusual. This

is a normal week', land with the flatness of someone stating a fact that should be shocking but no longer is , and it is this resignation that invites the reader's outrage on her behalf. The anecdote of Ella widens the appeal. Where Raman's own story speaks to fellow workers, Ella, who is 'nineteen', getting up at 4.30 and sitting 'in a café she can't really afford', speaks to parents and to anyone worried about whether young people have a future in the town . The decline of the train is gradually connected to the decline of the town itself .

Having made the problem personal, Raman then makes it measurable , arguing that the decline is real and that neither the alternatives nor the official excuses hold up. Her nine years on the line give her a before-and-after authority ('something you could set your watch by'), but she is careful not to rest on memory alone. The Rail Users Group figures, translated into plain fractions, 'nearly nine out of every ten' and 'fewer than seven', are easier for a general reader to feel than a percentage , and the accompanying graph turns this decline into something almost physical: eight bars stepping steadily down, with the final, darkest bar marking 69 per cent as the low point so far. The grey, unadorned design gives the graph the look of neutral data rather than campaign material , which strengthens its authority, while the inclusive 'us' in 'roughly one in three of us is late' quietly recruits every reader who has stood on that platform into her argument . Raman then raises the obvious objection, 'well, just drive', in a dismissive voice before dismantling it with arithmetic, 'close to $90 a day', and with an image that is hard to forget: driving down the highway after a night shift 'with your eyes closing'. By the time she concludes that the train is 'the cheapest, safest and most sensible way' to get to work, she has turned her opponents ' solution into further evidence for her own case. The same strategy appears in her response to the official explanation of 'ageing infrastructure'. Rather than disputing it, she concedes it ('I don't doubt it'), and then uses the concession against the government: the problems were identified 'back in 2019', yet there have been 'plenty of announcements and very little actual work'. The balanced structure of this phrase exposes the gap between words and action .

Raman's final argument is that regional people are being treated as an afterthought, and that the government must now act. Her indignation is at its most controlled in the comparison with the city. The list of 'new tunnels', 'new stations' and 'shiny new trains' is followed by 'Good on them', a concession that sounds generous but carries an edge of sarcasm . It allows Raman to avoid seeming resentful while still making the reader feel the unfairness, which she then names directly: people out here are 'an afterthought', as though 'our time somehow matters less'. The short rebuttal 'It does matter' marks a turning point ,

after which the letter widens its consequences to the whole community, including nurses resigning from her hospital and people who ‘are simply left standing on the platform’. Her conclusion then shifts from description to demand. The repeated ‘I am asking’ gives her requests the rhythm of a formal petition, and the requests themselves are deliberately modest, which makes refusing them seem unreasonable . Her final move is her most pointed: an invitation to the local member, ‘who I notice drives to Melbourne’, to catch the 6.12 with her. The aside is barbed, quietly suggesting that those who make decisions about the train do not have to live with it . The closing line, ‘If the train turns up’, returns to the dry humour of the opening, but now the joke has a sting , leaving the reader with the very uncertainty the whole letter has been arguing against.

Through a careful movement from comic anecdote to hard evidence, and from concession to challenge, Raman transforms a familiar local grievance into an argument about fairness and respect . Her readers are positioned not only to sympathise with her, but to see their own frustration reflected and justified, and to expect their local member to answer for it.

High-Scoring Vocabulary Bank

Precise analytical verbs and phrases to lift your expression out of the everyday. Swap the word you always reach for with one that says exactly what the author is doing.

Instead of “shows”

demonstrates · illustrates · reveals · highlights · conveys · depicts · exposes · emphasises · evokes · underscores · articulates · renders · constructs · establishes

Instead of “says”

asserts · contends · argues · maintains · proposes · insists · suggests · posits · claims · declares · affirms · implies · intimates

Instead of “does”

manipulates · constructs · orchestrates · positions · cultivates · provokes · reinforces · challenges · subverts · complicates · foregrounds · amplifies

Instead of “likes” / “doesn’t like”

favours | endorses | advocates for | embraces | rejects | condemns | critiques | denounces | disparages | repudiates

Argument analysis: persuasive techniques

appeals to fear | appeals to morality | appeals to justice | appeals to community values | appeals to nostalgia | invokes empathy | mobilises outrage | exploits uncertainty | leverages authority | constructs credibility

Argument analysis: audience positioning

positions the reader to | encourages the audience to | invites the reader to | pressures the audience to | compels the reader to | manipulates the audience into | frames the issue as | recasts the debate as | polarises the audience | aligns the reader with

Sophisticated linking words

Furthermore | Moreover | Consequently | Thus | Accordingly | Nevertheless | Conversely | Significantly | Implicitly | Ultimately

Pair with the Glossary of Techniques for the metalanguage itself.

Sentence Starters for Analytical Writing

A working vocabulary for Section C paragraphs — openers, connectives and reporting verbs, grouped by job. Click any phrase to copy it, then make it your own: the strongest analysis uses these as scaffolding, not wallpaper.

To introduce the issue

> *The recent controversy/problem/incident/debate over (event) has prompted a variety of opinions regarding (issue).*

To introduce evidence of persuasiveness

To affirm this, To attest to this, To confirm this, To endorse this, To further confirm, To further verify, To substantiate this, To support this, To verify this,

Body paragraphs

The author emphasises... The author endorses the argument that ... when ... The article gives prominence to... The author's attitude is exemplified by...

To explain the effects of language

affects | illustrates | reinforces | characterises | impacts on | reveals | demonstrates | implies | subverts | exemplifies | portrays | underscores

Alternatives to ‘presents’

conveys | explores | implies | demonstrates | illustrates | indicates | signals | suggests

Alternatives to ‘presents positively’

advocates | endorses | promotes | recommends | supports

Alternatives to ‘presents negatively’

challenges | condemns | critiques | exposes | questions

To compare and contrast

Similarly, … | In the same way … | Likewise, … | In opposition to this… | In comparison … | Complementary to this … | Then again, … | However, … | This is in contrast to … | In contrast, … | And yet … | Nevertheless, … | Conversely, …

Instead...
On the contrary, ...
On the other hand, ...
Notwithstanding ...
Whereas ...
In contrast to ...
That aside, ...
While this is the case ...
... disputes ...
Despite this, ...

To add ideas

Also, ...
Equally important ...
Subsequently, ...
Furthermore, ...
Moreover, ...
As well as ...
Next...
Another essential point...
Additionally, ...
More importantly, ...
In the same way ...
Another ...
Then, ...
In addition, ...
Besides, ...
Then again, ...
Firstly, ... secondly, ... thirdly, ... finally, ...
To elaborate, ...

To present uncommon or rare ideas

Seldom ...
Few ...
Not many ...
A few ...
... is uncommon ...
... is scarce ...
Rarely ...
... is rare ...
... is unusual ...

To present common or widespread ideas

Numerous ...
Many ...
More than ...
Several ...
Almost all ...
The majority ...
Most ...
Commonly ...
Significant ...
Is prevalent ...
Is usual ...
Usually ...

To give examples

For example, ...
... as can be seen in ...
... supports ...
An illustration of ...
... as demonstrated by ...
... is observed ...
Specifically, ...
Is shown ...
Exemplifies ...
Such as ...
As an example ...
To illustrate, ...
For instance, ...

To show relationships or outcome

Therefore ...
As a result ...
For that reason ...
Hence, ...
Otherwise, ...
Consequently, ...
The evidence suggests/shows ...
It can be seen that ...
With regard to ...
After examining ...
These factors contribute to ...
It is apparent that ...
Considering ... it can be concluded ...
Subsequently, ...
The effect is ...
The outcome is ...
The result ...
The correlation ...
The relationship ...
The link ...
The convergence ...
The connection ...
Interacts with ...
Affects ...
Thus it is ...
Causes ...
Influences ...
Predicts ...
Leads to ...
Informs ...
Presupposes ...
Emphasises ...
Demonstrates ...
Impacts on ...
Supports ...

To present prior or background ideas

In the past, ...
Historically, ...
Traditionally, ...
Customarily, ...
Beforehand, ...

Originally, ... | Prior to this, ... | Earlier, ... | Formerly, ... | Previously, ...

Over time, ... | At the time of ... | Conventionally, ... | Foundational to this is ...

In earlier ... | Initially, ... | At first, ... | Recently ... | Until now, ...

The traditional interpretation ...

To present others' ideas

According to ... | Based on the findings of ... it can be argued... | ... proposed that ...

As explained by ... | ... states that ... | ... claims that ... | However, ... stated that ...

... suggested ... | ... concluded that ... | Similarly, ... stated that ... | ... agreed that ...

Based on the ideas of ... | ... defined ... as ... | ... relates ... | As identified by ...

... disputed that ... | ... contrasts ... | With regard to ... argued that ... | ... confirmed that ...

Argues ... | Highlights ... | Demonstrates ... | Found that ... | Identifies ...

Wrote that ... | Demonstrated ... | Reported ... | Pointed out that ...

Maintained that ... | Hypothesised that ... | ... expressed the opinion that ...

Also mentioned ... | Asserts that ... | Identified ... | Goes on to state/suggest/say ...

Emphasises ... | Challenges the idea ... | Showed that ... | Explored the idea ...

Pair these with the High-Scoring Vocabulary Bank and the Section C essay structure.

Analysing Argument: Persuasive Techniques

VCE English Units 3 and 4 — Reference table

A reminder for students: naming a technique earns no marks on its own. Strong analysis explains how the technique works within the wider argument — what it positions the intended audience to think or feel, and why the writer has placed it where they have. The examples below are constructed for illustration.

Appeals to emotion and values

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Appeal to fear	Warns of a threatening or damaging outcome if the reader does not accept the contention.	"Unless council acts now, our children will inherit streets choked by traffic and fumes."	Positions readers to feel anxious about the consequences of inaction, so that supporting the writer's proposal seems the only responsible, protective choice.
Appeal to family values	Invokes the reader's role as a parent, child or family member and the desire to protect loved ones.	"What parent would knowingly send their child into a classroom like this?"	Encourages readers to judge the issue through the lens of protecting their own family, making opposition feel like negligence rather than disagreement.
Appeal to patriotism / national pride	Links the contention to shared national identity, symbols or values.	"This is not the fair go that Australians have always believed in."	Invites readers to defend a national ideal, so that agreeing feels like an act of loyalty and disagreeing feels un-Australian.
Appeal to self-interest	Frames the argument in terms of direct personal benefit or loss to the reader.	"Every hour stuck in traffic is an hour stolen from your own weekend."	Prompts readers to see a personal stake in an otherwise abstract issue, making them more likely to act.
Appeal to the hip-pocket nerve	A specific form of self-interest focused on money, taxes, rates or household costs.	"Ratepayers will foot the $4.2 million bill for a footbridge nobody asked for."	Positions readers as taxpayers being taken advantage of, generating resentment towards the opposing side.
Appeal to tradition / nostalgia	Draws on an idealised past or long-standing custom as a reason to preserve or restore something.	"For generations, Saturday morning sport has been a rite of passage in this town."	Encourages readers to feel that something valuable is being lost, framing change as vandalism rather than progress.
Appeal to justice and fairness	Argues that a situation breaches principles of equity or a "level playing field".	"It is simply not right that one school receives twice the funding of the school next door."	Invites readers to feel moral indignation, positioning the writer as the defender of fairness.
Appeal to common sense	Presents the contention as self-evident to any reasonable person.	"Any sensible person can see that a two-hour commute is not sustainable."	Discourages scrutiny by implying that disagreement would expose the reader as foolish or out of touch.
Appeal to authority / expert opinion	Cites recognised specialists, institutions or officials to lend weight to a claim.	"The Royal Children's Hospital has warned repeatedly about the risks."	Reassures readers that the position is credible and evidence-based, and makes disagreement seem uninformed.
Appeal to group loyalty / belonging	Constructs a shared community identity that the reader is invited to join.	"We in the western suburbs know exactly what neglect looks like."	Creates solidarity between writer and reader, positioning opponents as outsiders who do not understand.

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Appeal to pity / compassion	Foregrounds the suffering or vulnerability of a person or group.	“Maria, seventy-eight and legally blind, now waits ninety minutes for a bus that once ran hourly.”	Elicits sympathy, making the reader feel that supporting the contention is an act of decency.
Appeal to responsibility / duty	Frames action as an obligation owed to others, often future generations.	“We owe it to the students who come after us to fix this now.”	Places a moral burden on readers, so that inaction feels like a failure of character.
Appeal to hope / optimism	Paints a positive vision of what is achievable.	“Imagine a foreshore where families gather instead of a fenced-off carpark.”	Encourages readers to invest emotionally in an appealing future and to associate the writer with it.
Appeal to guilt or shame	Suggests the reader is complicit in a wrong through silence or inaction.	“Every one of us who scrolled past that report shares a little of the blame.”	Makes readers uncomfortable with their own passivity, motivating them to act in order to relieve that discomfort.
Appeal to modernity / progress	Portrays the opposing view as outdated and the contention as forward-thinking.	“It is 2026, and we are still arguing about whether women deserve equal pay.”	Positions opponents as backward, so that agreement becomes a way of aligning oneself with progress.
Appeal to freedom and individual rights	Frames the issue as one of personal liberty or civil rights.	“No government should dictate what a family reads at the dinner table.”	Provokes resistance to perceived overreach, encouraging readers to defend their autonomy.
Appeal to security and safety	Emphasises the need for protection, order or stability.	“Residents deserve to walk to the station after dark without checking over their shoulder.”	Positions the proposal as a basic protection, making opposition appear indifferent to public wellbeing.

Language and word choice

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Emotive language	Word choices selected primarily for their emotional charge rather than their descriptive accuracy.	“The proposal will devastate a fragile, irreplaceable wetland.”	Heightens the reader’s emotional response so that the issue feels urgent and the stakes catastrophic.
Connotation	The associations a word carries beyond its literal meaning.	Describing protesters as a “mob” rather than a “gathering”.	Shapes the reader’s attitude towards a group before any evidence is offered, colouring the whole argument.
Labelling and naming	Assigning a loaded name or category to people, policies or ideas.	Calling the levy a “commuter tax” rather than a “network contribution”.	Fixes a negative frame in the reader’s mind that persists even when counter-evidence appears.
Inclusive language	First-person plural pronouns (“we”, “us”, “our”) that fold the reader into the writer’s position.	“Our streets, our schools, our responsibility.”	Blurs the line between writer and reader so the contention feels like a shared conviction rather than one person’s opinion.
Exclusive language	Third-person pronouns (“they”, “them”, “those people”) that separate the opposition from the reader.	“They sit in Spring Street and decide what our suburb needs.”	Creates an in-group and an out-group, encouraging readers to distrust the opposition on principle.
Colloquial language	Informal, everyday expressions and slang.	“Let’s be honest — the whole thing’s a dog’s breakfast.”	Builds rapport and makes the writer seem down-to-earth and trustworthy, like someone speaking plainly.
Formal register and technical jargon	Specialist or elevated vocabulary drawn from a professional field.	“The catchment’s hydrological load exceeds design tolerance.”	Signals expertise and authority, making the argument appear rigorous and difficult for a lay reader to

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
			challenge.
Euphemism	A mild or vague expression substituted for something harsh.	Referring to job losses as “workforce realignment”.	Softens the reader’s reaction to an unpalatable reality, reducing the likelihood of outrage.
Dysphemism	A deliberately harsh or ugly term used in place of a neutral one.	Describing the development as “concrete sprawl”.	Intensifies the reader’s disgust, ensuring the subject is judged negatively before it is examined.
Cliche	A familiar, well-worn phrase.	“At the end of the day, actions speak louder than words.”	Offers instant, effortless agreement by drawing on a phrase the reader already accepts as true.
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration for effect.	“The queue at the clinic stretched halfway to the border.”	Amplifies the scale of the problem so readers perceive it as intolerable and demanding immediate attention.
Understatement / litotes	Deliberately downplaying something significant, often ironically.	“A fourteen-week wait for surgery is not ideal.”	Invites readers to supply the outrage themselves, which can feel more persuasive than being told what to feel.
Superlatives and absolutes	Words such as “never”, “always”, “everyone”, “worst” that admit no exceptions.	“This is the worst planning decision the shire has ever made.”	Projects certainty and closes down the possibility of qualification or middle ground.
High modality	Verbs and adverbs expressing certainty or obligation — “must”, “undoubtedly”, “will”.	“Council must reverse this decision immediately.”	Conveys conviction and urgency, positioning the contention as beyond reasonable dispute.
Low modality	Tentative language — “might”, “perhaps”, “it could be argued”.	“There may be room to reconsider the timeline.”	Makes the writer seem reasonable and open-minded, which can disarm a hostile reader.
Imperatives and direct address	Commands, and second-person address to the reader.	“Write to your member. Do it today.”	Converts agreement into action by making the reader feel personally instructed and accountable.
Neologism and coinage	Inventing a new word or phrase to name a phenomenon.	“The ‘commute-and-collapse’ generation.”	Gives the reader a memorable handle for the writer’s framing of the issue, making it easier to recall and repeat.
Allusion	A reference to a well-known text, event, person or story.	“This is a David-and-Goliath fight, and Goliath owns the land.”	Borrows the emotional and moral weight of the referenced story, casting the sides in familiar roles.
Pun and wordplay	Play on multiple meanings or similar-sounding words, common in headlines.	Headline: “Bridge over troubled ratepayers”.	Entertains the reader and lowers resistance, while compressing a judgement into a memorable phrase.
Slogan / sound bite	A short, rhythmic, repeatable phrase encapsulating the contention.	“Fund the future, not the freeway.”	Makes the argument portable and memorable, so it survives long after the details are forgotten.

Rhetorical and structural devices

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Rhetorical question	A question posed for effect rather than to elicit an	“How many more reports must gather dust before	Draws readers into constructing the answer

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
	answer.	something changes?”	themselves, making them feel they have reasoned their way to the writer’s position.
Repetition	Deliberate restatement of a word, phrase or idea.	“It is unsafe. It is unfair. It is unfinished.”	Reinforces the key idea until it feels self-evident, and lends the prose a rhythm that carries the reader along.
Anaphora	Repetition of the same word or phrase at the start of successive clauses or sentences.	“We warned them in March. We warned them in June. We warned them again last week.”	Builds cumulative momentum and a sense of mounting grievance.
Rule of three (tricolon)	Grouping ideas, images or examples in threes.	“Safer streets, shorter waits, stronger communities.”	Creates a satisfying, complete-sounding rhythm that makes the claim feel thorough and well-considered.
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds.	“A policy of delay, denial and disregard.”	Makes phrasing memorable and emphatic, drawing the reader’s attention to the words the writer most wants retained.
Antithesis	Balanced contrast of opposing ideas within a sentence.	“They promised transparency; they delivered silence.”	Sharpens the contrast between the two sides, making the opposition’s failure appear stark and deliberate.
Juxtaposition and contrast	Placing two contrasting situations, images or figures side by side.	A photograph of the new stadium beside a shot of the closed community pool.	Invites readers to draw an unfavourable comparison themselves, which feels like their own conclusion.
Metaphor	An implied comparison in which one thing is described as another.	“The budget is a house of cards.”	Compresses a complex judgement into a vivid image, encouraging readers to accept the comparison’s implications.
Extended metaphor	A metaphor sustained and developed across a passage.	A whole column framing the planning process as a slow-moving train wreck.	Structures the reader’s understanding of the entire issue, so every detail is interpreted through the chosen frame.
Simile	An explicit comparison using “like” or “as”.	“The consultation was like being asked to choose the colour of a wall already painted.”	Makes an abstract complaint concrete and often faintly absurd, encouraging shared derision.
Analogy	An extended comparison to a simpler or more familiar situation.	“Cutting maintenance to save money is like skipping servicing to keep your car on the road.”	Transfers the reader’s confident judgement about the familiar case onto the unfamiliar one.
Personification	Attributing human qualities to an object, place or abstraction.	“The river has been strangled by a century of neglect.”	Encourages readers to feel sympathy for a non-human subject, raising the emotional stakes.
Sarcasm	Mocking praise or comment whose intended meaning is the opposite of what is said.	“What a triumph of planning — a bus lane that ends in a roundabout.”	Ridicules the opposition and invites readers to share the writer’s scorn, positioning them as equally clear-sighted.
Irony	A gap between what is stated or expected and what is actually the case.	“The road safety forum was cancelled because delegates could not get there safely.”	Exposes contradiction in the opposing position, undermining its credibility without direct attack.
Humour	Wit, absurdity or comic exaggeration used within an argument.	“The strategy runs to 240 pages, which is 239 more than the plan it replaces.”	Makes the writer likeable and disarms resistance, so criticism is absorbed with less defensiveness.

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Anecdote	A brief personal story used to illustrate the argument.	“Last winter I watched a man in a wheelchair turned away from the only accessible entrance.”	Converts statistics into a human face, making the issue emotionally real and difficult to dismiss.
Framing / defining the issue	Establishing at the outset what the debate is “really” about.	“This is not a debate about parking. It is a debate about who this city is for.”	Controls the terms of the discussion, so the opposition is forced to argue on the writer’s chosen ground.
Concession	Openly acknowledging a point in the opposing argument.	“Critics are right that the cost is significant.”	Makes the writer appear fair-minded and balanced, increasing the reader’s trust in what follows.
Rebuttal	Directly answering and dismantling an opposing argument.	“But the claim that the levy is temporary collapses the moment you read clause 14.”	Reassures readers that objections have been considered and defeated, leaving no obvious escape from the contention.
Pre-emption / anticipating objections	Raising a likely counter-argument before the reader can.	“Some will say we cannot afford it. In fact, we cannot afford not to.”	Defuses resistance before it forms and positions the writer as several steps ahead of the sceptic.
Call to action	A closing exhortation directing the reader to do something specific.	“Sign the petition before Friday’s meeting.”	Channels the emotion generated by the piece into a concrete behaviour, giving the reader an outlet.
Climactic ordering	Arranging points so they escalate in force towards the end.	Moving from inconvenience, to cost, to a child’s injury.	Leaves readers with the most powerful impression at the point where the argument is meant to land.
Headline and opening hook	The title and first lines, engineered for impact.	“The bridge to nowhere — and the suburb paying for it”	Fixes the reader’s interpretive frame before the argument begins and compels them to read on.

Evidence and support

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Statistics	Numerical data cited in support of a claim.	“Emergency department waits have risen 34 per cent since 2023.”	Lends an air of objectivity and scale, making the problem seem measurable and therefore undeniable.
Research and studies	Reference to formal investigations, reports or peer-reviewed findings.	“A Monash University study tracked 4,000 commuters over five years.”	Signals rigour, positioning the contention as grounded in fact rather than opinion.
Expert testimony	Direct quotation from a credentialed specialist.	“Professor Nguyen, a paediatric respiratory specialist, calls the air quality ‘indefensible’.”	Transfers the expert’s authority to the writer’s case and makes disagreement look like amateur second-guessing.
Eyewitness or vox pop quotation	Quoting ordinary people affected by the issue.	“‘I’ve stopped letting the kids ride to school,’ says local parent Dee Halloran.”	Grounds the argument in lived experience and suggests broad community agreement.
Personal experience and credentials	The writer establishing their own standing to speak on the issue.	“In twenty-two years as a paramedic in this area, I have never seen it this bad.”	Builds ethos, encouraging readers to trust the writer’s judgement even where evidence is thin.
Historical precedent	Reference to comparable past events or decisions.	“We made this mistake with the Eastern Freeway in 1977.”	Suggests the outcome is predictable, framing the opposition as ignoring the lessons of experience.

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Comparison to other jurisdictions	Citing what other cities, states or countries do.	"Copenhagen solved this a decade ago for a fraction of the cost."	Implies the proposal is proven and low-risk, and that resistance is parochial or lazy.
Official documentation	Quoting legislation, budget papers, minutes or freedom-of-information material.	"The council's own minutes record the risk as 'high and unmitigated'."	Creates the impression of insider knowledge and hard proof, heightening the sense of exposure or scandal.

Reasoning, logic and logical fallacies

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Logical reasoning / cause and effect	A sequence of connected claims leading to a conclusion.	"Fewer services mean longer waits; longer waits mean people drive; more driving means more congestion."	Gives the argument the feel of inevitability, so the conclusion seems to follow whether or not the reader agrees emotionally.
Generalisation	A sweeping claim about a whole group based on limited cases.	"Young people today simply will not take on trade apprenticeships."	Simplifies a complex reality into something the reader can accept quickly, though it invites challenge if noticed.
Slippery slope	Claiming one small step will lead inexorably to an extreme outcome.	"First it is one street closure; soon no one will be able to drive anywhere."	Amplifies fear by attaching disproportionate consequences to a modest proposal.
False dichotomy (either–or)	Presenting only two options when others exist.	"We either fund the upgrade or accept that people will die on this road."	Forces readers into the writer's preferred option by making the alternative appear unthinkable.
Bandwagon	Suggesting that most people already agree.	"More than 9,000 residents have already signed."	Exploits the reader's desire to belong, making dissent feel isolating and eccentric.
Attack / ad hominem	Criticising the person rather than their argument.	"Of course the developer's consultant says it is safe — he is paid to."	Discredits the opposing case by association, so readers dismiss it without weighing its merits.
Straw man	Misrepresenting the opposing position in a weakened form, then refuting it.	"They want to ban cars altogether."	Gives the writer an easy victory and makes the opposition appear extreme.
Circular reasoning	Using the conclusion as its own justification.	"The plan is necessary because without it we would not have a plan."	Can pass unnoticed in fluent prose, leaving readers with a sense of having been given a reason.
Reductio ad absurdum	Following the opposing logic to a ridiculous conclusion.	"By that reasoning we should close the hospital to reduce the road toll."	Exposes the opposition as incoherent and invites the reader to laugh at it.
Post hoc reasoning	Assuming that because one event followed another, it was caused by it.	"Since the speed limit dropped, business on the strip has collapsed."	Offers a simple, satisfying explanation that readers may accept without interrogating the causal link.
Red herring	Introducing an irrelevant issue to divert attention.	Responding to safety concerns by discussing the objectors' political affiliations.	Shifts the ground of debate away from the writer's weakest point.

Tone

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Tone	The writer's attitude towards subject and audience, conveyed through word choice, syntax and imagery.	A measured, reasonable tone throughout an opinion piece on school funding.	Frames how every other technique is received; a reasonable tone makes even forceful claims seem balanced and trustworthy.
Tone shift	A deliberate change of attitude at a specific point in the text.	Moving from wry humour in the opening to grave sincerity in the final paragraph.	Jolts the reader out of comfort and signals that the closing point is the one that matters most.
Outraged / indignant tone	Expressing anger at injustice or incompetence.	"It is an insult — there is no gentler word — to every family on that waiting list."	Licenses the reader's own anger and makes calm acceptance of the status quo feel inadequate.
Reasonable / conciliatory tone	Calm, balanced and willing to acknowledge complexity.	"Reasonable people can disagree here, and many do."	Positions the writer as the sensible voice in a heated debate, making the opposition seem shrill by comparison.

Visual language

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Political cartoon	A drawing using caricature, symbolism and captions to make an argument.	A cartoon of a minister padlocking a school gate labelled 'CONSULTATION'.	Delivers a complete argument at a glance and invites readers to enjoy the ridicule of the target.
Caricature and exaggeration	Distorting a figure's features or scale.	A developer drawn with enormous hands clutching a tiny park.	Reduces a person or group to a single unflattering trait, making them easy to dismiss.
Symbolism	Using an object or image to stand for a larger idea.	An hourglass with the last grains falling.	Compresses an abstract claim about urgency into an image readers grasp instantly.
Labelling in cartoons	Written tags attached to figures or objects in an image.	A sinking boat labelled 'PUBLIC TRANSPORT'.	Removes ambiguity, ensuring the reader interprets the image exactly as the cartoonist intends.
Facial expression and body language	The postures and expressions given to figures in an image.	A weary nurse slumped against a corridor wall.	Provokes an immediate empathetic response that bypasses reasoned argument.
Photograph	A selected image accompanying a written text.	A photograph of a flooded classroom.	Offers apparently objective proof while the framing and moment chosen carry the persuasive work.
Gaze and vectors	The direction in which figures look, or lines that lead the eye.	A child looking directly out of the frame at the reader.	Creates a sense of direct address and personal appeal, drawing the reader into the subject's situation.
Salience and size	What is made most visually prominent through scale or placement.	A bulldozer dominating the foreground, protesters tiny behind it.	Establishes a visual hierarchy that mirrors the argument's power relations before any text is read.
Colour	The palette used and the associations it carries.	Sickly greens and greys in an image of a polluted creek.	Sets an emotional register instantly, priming the reader to feel unease or optimism.

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Caption	Text accompanying an image that directs its interpretation.	“The playground, six months after the promised upgrade.”	Anchors an ambiguous image to a single reading that supports the written argument.
Graphs and infographics	Data presented visually through charts or diagrams.	A steeply rising line graph of ambulance ramping hours.	Makes a trend look dramatic and self-evident, lending the argument the authority of data.
Layout, subheadings and pull quotes	The visual organisation of a text and the extraction of key lines.	A pull quote in large type: ‘Nobody is coming to fix this.’	Guides skim-readers to the most emotive material and gives certain claims disproportionate weight.
Logos and branding	Organisational marks or mastheads within a text.	A hospital foundation logo beside a fundraising appeal.	Borrows established institutional credibility to make the appeal feel legitimate.
Visual juxtaposition	Two contrasting images placed together.	A glossy artist’s impression beside a photograph of the actual site.	Invites readers to detect a gap between promise and reality, generating distrust of the opposing side.